

Maybe Baby

By Annie McHugh

Maybe Love

Chapter 1

Other kids play pirate ship with cardboard refrigerator boxes, but I actually live on one. A year ago my parents took my twin brother and I out of middle school, had a really big tag sale, and sold our family minivan. The plan was to live on our pirate ship, aka the catamaran Anco, and to sail around the Caribbean until they don't want to anymore, or the money runs out, whichever comes first. Although, everyday it seems they concoct new schemes about how to make money on the high seas so we can stay longer. Their current plan is to find and train a small monkey from the islands to tap dance and eat pineapples instead of bananas. They say people will pay a lot of money to see that. But if I had a lot of money I probably wouldn't spend it on that.

My parents are always telling my brother and I to follow our dreams, to find what we love and go after it. They say they don't know why they ever waited so long to do what they really wanted to do. Dad is currently taking a sabbatical from his tenure at a university in our hometown in Maine. Mom told the book club she wouldn't be around for a while and left her job at the library. She said she was tired of reading about all these great adventures and that it was finally time for her to have one of her own. By default, we get one too.

Cole and I, on the other hand, we thought junior high was adventure enough. We were upset at first when Mom and Dad said we wouldn't be going back to finish our last year. But we got over it as soon as we saw the beautiful beaches and sea glass green water of the Caribbean. Now I kind of like it when they plan how to make a living out here, and with high school on the horizon I don't think I'd ever want to go back.

Today Cole and I walk around the street bazaar and eat yellow rice with chorizo and red peppers from paper cups. It is so hot outside that my long hair sticks to my neck in ornate patterns like the lattice work on the antique chairs of the Caribbean. Whenever possible we stand in the shade of awnings and turquoise roof overhangs. We hop from one spot to the next like we used to do on the furniture in our living room to avoid the hot-hot lava otherwise known as the carpet.

A reggae band plays near us. The ringing of tin drums and deep heart throbbing beats fill the street. The singer's voice reminds me of a dark chocolate nougat filled Milky Way, and shooting stars when there's a full moon.

Locals sell incense and dried herbs, woven scarves and blankets to use as throws and tapestries, books about the native landscape and history, summer sandals and fringed bikinis and tanning oil. They sell paperback novels, silk dresses, artificial flowers, homemade dolls and wooden statues carved into turtles and parrots and intertwined hearts. There is also the Village Silversmith, Rico. He's not always here, but when he is I love looking at his intricate rings and designs. Each one is like a tiny world with its own myths of creation and redemption. He is a gypsy. He has a big sun-burned belly and wears a seashell pendant, with a strange etched symbol on its underbelly, that pops against the redness of his skin. I like to pretend it's the key to open some ancient room of knowledge. I look for him today but he's not here.

Instead, we come across a group of street performers. We push our little bodies through the throngs of people and get a view up front, close to the action, that's where I like to be. The sound of the steel drums is behind us and now we hear a light flute melody from an instrument I've never seen before. The performers are unlike any I've ever seen before too. I look at Cole and our eyes open wide. We've seen a lot in our travels so far but nothing quite like this. We've

seen men in turbans lay on beds of nails, and real daredevils who swallow fire and swords and breathe colored flames on which we could roast marshmallows. We've seen teams of young rock solid guys hip-hopping and beat-boxing, magicians, and jugglers. We've even seen one lady hypnotize a snake to wrap itself around her body as clothing. That was weird. It could've eaten her alive.

But these people today are different. They aren't jumping around or trying to rile up the audience. They aren't selling anything. There are no gimmicks. They aren't even loud or passing around a bucket. People in the crowd are captivated, they get quiet and their faces look so serious, they don't blink. They try not to move themselves, a mirror of the state of mind of the statuesque performer before us, any sudden movement might break the spell. I find myself pulled into this trance-like awe too.

The man has short brown hair buzzed to his head. His eyes are closed and plump like pillows, or ravioli. His face is so silent it's as if lines have never broken its surface. His body doesn't even move with his breath. His inhales and exhales are so long he might not even be breathing, they run across time as if it doesn't exist.

Then his eyes open smoothly as if he has been looking at something all along, something just in front of him that no one else can see. Everyone around us huddles closer in, they wait to hear a whispered secret. The man, from a crossed leg position with each foot on top of each thigh, begins to move in slow motion. He places his hands on the ground in front of his knees, he effortlessly transfers all of his weight into his arms and, like a drawbridge opens, lifts his crossed legs off the ground and into the air over his head. His white tunic and pants stay close to his body. It still looks like he's not even breathing, and his eyes don't even blink. I count in my head how long he stays in the air, but the numbers get too big and I stop. Instead, my mind becomes mesmerized as I watch this man in stillness, and it stops making any noise. I don't think about anything else. My mind is balanced on a tightrope suspended by this image of quiet and stillness from the human body. I have never held my body or mind so still.

The man moves through a few more poses with fluidity. He holds each one for at least fifteen minutes and before I know it much of the afternoon has already passed. Cole tugs on my t-shirt, distracted by a cart vending colorful streamers and balloons. It passes us by on rickety wooden wheels that remind me of a jostling roller coaster. It pulls my attention away from the man in white, like pulling a plastic suction cup off a glass window. The more Cole tugs, the more my tentacles of attention loosen their grip and bring me back to reality, beamed back down by a spaceship.

"Wait, look," I say to him. The man finishes his last pose and another member of the team places a large oval seashell in front of him as an offering dish with a sign. The sign says all the polite things it should say about money and includes a short note that anyone interested may come and study with the monks to learn the form of yoga and meditation just demonstrated. I feel the sinews of my muscles flex and reach outward as if for the wings of a giant bird to soar on and be carried up to the heights, only it tells me to walk towards the monks instead. My muscles itch, my bones pulse with fresh marrow inside of them, it circulates like the fizz of ginger ale.

"I want to do that," I tell Cole.

"You're not going to join the freaks, Annika," Cole says, "Mom and Dad would flip."

"No they wouldn't. They want to buy a monkey and make it eat pineapples. They'd eat this up. They'll probably make you do it too." I smile mischievously.

He gives me a look like he's begging for his life. I may only be older by two minutes and

twenty three seconds but I certainly know how to wield the power.

We climb back through the crowd. In the light Caribbean breeze brightly colored beads dangle from tents and carts on the side of the road. We smell the sugary tartness of lime and coconut mixed into drinks we've never tasted. We hear the tropical birds call out in the hazy sunset for another night of salty dreams and fluorescent wishes. The clouds swirl into crystals and gemstones, exposing the intimacies of the earth, hanging them in the air for all to see. We crawl over rocks by the shore that are too craggy to stand on, and we chase each other through the sand. We laugh and run until our sides hurt and we forget what it's like to breathe. We buy lemon and raspberry ice slushies on the way home and see who can eat them the fastest before a brain freeze. I can't imagine ever going back to school, or Maine, or indoor grocery stores and shopping plazas.

This is wild. This is exotic. This is tangles in my hair and bare feet on the pavement. It's lavender sleep and Swiss Family Robinson meets Robinson Crusoe dreams. It's secret forts in the trees, and skyway highways, and talking to the animals. It's the purest ninety-nine percent dark chocolate cacao brought back from regal expeditions commissioned by kings and queens. It's life, worth living.

Chapter 2

At the dockyard where our boat is, the wooden planks creak and crack as they hover on the water. Our sandals flip and flop as we walk down the length of the dock and hop on board Anco, with her Mount Everest tall masts and un-tearable sails. We're just in time for our curfew: when the sun disappears below the yellow rooftop in the distance. Cole and I wash our hands and faces. Mom lights the lanterns that line the deck top so you can see shadows dance across the inscriptions all along the length of the ship. They tell ancient stories that may or may not be true. She plays her favorite mix of opera music and Broadway. Dad brings the blue duffel bag out from the cabin and starts unpacking in the cockpit. We all join him as he pulls out decks of cards, board games, volumes of Shakespeare, and art supplies. Sometimes we take turns reading parts in the bard's plays. Sometimes we make up our own. Sometimes we all study history or science or math or literature together, and it's more like entertainment than home schooling. It's fascinating. Our parents know a lot of stuff and we ask a lot of questions.

Tonight we're playing Monopoly. That means we get to learn about buying houses, taxes, real estate, renting, mortgages, and bankruptcy. I tend to think it is irrelevant whenever we do this because I want to live on our boat the rest of my life. But Dad always says if something is happening right now, like playing this game, then it is always relevant.

I always like this game because it lasts forever, it usually takes more than three hours to play so we get to stay up late. It also usually means that Mom and Dad want to have some kind of big family discussion and are giving us a time frame in which to have it. Tonight I'm wondering when it will begin. We've already goen around the board three times and I'm starting to feel anxious. What do they want to talk about? Cole eyes me nervously. He knows something is up too. Maybe they really found a monkey. Or it's time to move to the next island on our adventure.

Then, after we take mortgages and second mortgages and Mom as the banker declares Dad bankrupt, Dad says, "I guess this is a good time to tell you." He looks at Mom and she nods her head.

They are silent, Cole and I lean in closer and closer. Finally Cole says, “Just tell us already!”

“Well,” Dad repeats himself, “I guess this is a good time to tell you that we’ve finally reached our spending limit and it’s time for us to go back home.” Beat. “Your turn, Annika.”

I don’t move. How can I? This is like the stillness that the man had earlier in the day except that my insides are unleashing earthquakes and tornados. I don’t feel my heart beating for all the Shakespearian maelstrom, the breath in my lungs is trapped there waiting to exhale, my eyelids never move. Then out of the rubble, thought after thought seeps into my brain, swirling around and around, each calling themselves the most important. But I can’t put words to any of them.

“Annika, go,” my brother demands. I can hardly remember how to play the game.

“No. What do you mean we’re going home?” I push my little silver top hat off the game board, losing my place.

Mom answers, “It’s time, honey. You knew this day would come. There is a time for everything.”

“It’s not time. I don’t think it’s time. It’s definitely not time for me. I don’t want to go home. I want to stay here. It’s so different from anything else we have at home. Please don’t make us go yet.”

I look at Mom and Dad knowing they’ve already made their decision and there’s nothing I can do to change it. This is not a family democracy. I know Cole feels the same way as me but he won’t say anything. So I ask, and he says, “Whatever.” Now I’m in a bad mood the rest of the night. I reinstate my piece haphazardly on the board, make sloppy decisions and moves, and finally play myself out of the game.

“When are we leaving?” I ask.

Mom answers, “Tomorrow morning.”

I hold everything I want to say, inward. I walk up to the bow of the boat and lay down in the rope canopy. I look up at the same moon I’ll be seeing from home again soon. I hear the clank of the ship masts and ropes brushing together in the breezy air, the slosh of the water against the sides of the boats, and the creaking and groaning of the dock beside me. That’s how I feel inside.

Cole walks up to me and sits down too.

“Why didn’t you say anything when Mom and Dad said we’re leaving? Don’t you want to stay?” I ask.

“I don’t know. They make the rules. I just do what I’m supposed to.”

“What if they told you to jump off a bridge, or into a fire?”

“That’s stupid, Annika, and they wouldn’t.”

“But what if they did?”

“Then I would. They’d probably have a plan to pull me out. But even if they didn’t pull me out, I’d still trust their decision.”

“Now *that’s* stupid. Why would you do that?”

“Because they love us.”

“If they love us then why aren’t we staying? It doesn’t make sense to me,” I’m exasperated.

“Then stop looking at it from your perspective,” Cole says.

Touche. We stop talking. I’m irritated. I’m itchy. I climb into my bunk below deck and look at my collection of beach debris lined up along the wooden shelf. I have soda can tabs,

broken shells, swiss cheese looking driftwood, lumpy rocks, and small bottles of sand. Dad told me that glass is made from sand, so when I look at it I always think of the miracle transformation of something so rough becoming so smooth and pure. Maybe there are other things like that too. Maybe they are hidden in just the same way as sand.

Of all the things I've found, though, I really still want to find one perfect shell, just to know it exists, just to hold something so perfectly designed and created. But I haven't found it yet, even from all the places and beaches we've been to. Maybe it doesn't exist.

I close my eyes, and wait to be rocked to sleep by the gentle sway of the boat. I try not to think about the stillness of my own bed at home and returning to it soon. But the more I try not to, the more I do, and it's like I'm already there. Then I resolve, there must be a way to stay.

Chapter 3

Before sunrise I climb out to my favorite waterfall. No one wakes up on the boat when I leave, they can sleep through anything. The waterfall catches the light and lets it bleed across the fall like water color paint as the sun emerges from the sea.

I imagine the waterfall rushing inside of me, it washes everything away until there is stillness. I imagine the rush falling on top of me, filling me up with its crystal clear water, cold and pure and pristine. The falling is comforting. It's letting go. It's cleansing. It's talk of the secrets in the morning. It reminds me of the girl in Scott O'Dell's *Island of the Blue Dolphins*. She taught me a lot about not being afraid to be alone. I have to find it sometimes though. I have to seek it out, I have to want that stillness more than whatever everyone else is doing. Then I hear a small still voice saying, "You found me." I want to stay there longer and longer and longer. I want to know more about that place. I want to explore it the way I explore the island. I have a feeling its riches will never end, its boundaries are beyond time, and its weather is always perfect for walking in the cool of the day.

I want to bring my brother to this place. I want to show my parents. But maybe they need to find it by themselves, to seek it out like buried treasure. I could describe it to them though, the way an explorer describes a new found land and inspires others to make the voyage and see it for themselves.

After the sun is fully revealed in the sky I say goodbye to my favorite place and head back to Anco before anyone else is up. On the way I walk through the early morning stir of the street bazaar. Tents and zippers turn into recognizable shapes from heaps on the ground. Dough evolves from wheat and yeast in sweet breads and cakes. The morning rumble births the first sound of the steel drum rhythm that sets the pace for the day.

In the back corner of the bazaar I see the silversmith setting up shop. He's one of the few who is not always here. He's an island hopper. He travels from island to island to sell his goods rather than always staying here. I'm glad to see him today so I can say goodbye. I walk up to his cart decorated with coral and seaweed and he recognizes me instantly.

"Ah, Little One, how are you doing? Did you see the sunrise this morning?"

"Yeah. It sparkled like fairies jumping through the waterfall."

"Look what I found, Little One."

Even though I'm fourteen I like that he calls me that. It reminds me of my Grandpa. It makes me feel protected.

I peer into his hand. I can't believe my eyes. It's a perfect-perfect-perfect un-chipped, brilliantly white and smooth-underneath seashell.

"It is possible!" I gasp. "Where did you find it?"

"On the next island over. I've been looking for a long time."

"Do you think there are more? Do you think I could find one?"

"Sure, if you keep on looking."

"Can I hold it?"

He gently places the shell in my hand. It's heavier than it looks. I feel all around it, trying to memorize its perfection, knowing it exists, and hoping that one could be mine too. I think maybe he will give it to me like he has done with some of his findings in the past, but this one is too precious and he takes it back saying, "You'll find your own."

He'll probably work it into one of his designs, turn it into a necklace or fat statement ring. Maybe he will find a match and make earrings. Or maybe he'll just keep it close for inspiration.

"Can I buy it from you?" I ask.

"No," he answers with a chuckle before I can even say it. "It won't be the same to you if you do. You'll find one, just keep looking."

We kind of smile at each other and say goodbye. I take one last early morning stroll through the streets, before anyone is awake enough to solicit my attention for their hard worked handicrafts. I pull some leaves off a tree to take with me for my collection. The morning is starting to smell like thunder clouds and feel like sticky tape against my skin. I wonder if Mom and Dad will postpone our trip if the weather is bad.

When I get back to the boat they're already up and busy prepping the sails. They have all our foul weather gear stacked in the cockpit. Mine is a neon pink full body jumpsuit with a hood.

"Annika," Mom shouts, "hop on board. We want to try and beat the weather, at least make it to St. Kitt's before the downpour."

Now, we've sailed in the rain before but never by choice. I can't help but think what could be so important that we have to leave now and risk our lives rather than wait for better weather. Then, almost like reading my mind, Dad says, "And don't think we're going to stay an extra few days because of the weather, young lady, it'll just be some light rain if anything, nothing to worry about. We're heading in the opposite direction of the storm so it shouldn't catch us. Besides, you're my pro at sailing in the rain, remember?"

How could I forget? The first time he ever took me out to learn how to sail, just me and him, the most perfect day turned into the most perfect storm. There were ten foot swells carrying our little boat like a roller coaster. I remember seeing skeletons in my mind dancing to death at a Día de los Muertos celebration. Day of the Dead. Little skulls and moroccos. The spray in my face made me unable to see. I couldn't walk steady on the boat. Dad hooked a line from the railing to my life jacket for safety. I was so afraid the adrenaline kept me from crying. Lightning turned the whole sky purple and I saw him against the horizon as clear as if it were day in the darkness. He radioed for help but no one came. Something was wrong with the instruments. I've never been so scared in my life.

"Fine, but I'm staying in the cabin," I relent.

"No, you're not. We need you at your position to man the helm and stir us out of here. You can ditch the attitude down there though," mom says.

I roll my eyes and head down below with my neon radio-active-protection suit to add the last picked leaves to my collection. I put on my jumpsuit just in case. I might be sad about

leaving but I really shouldn't take it out on them.

Below deck, when I see all of my treasures, ripples of resistance course through me. I don't want to leave. I look at our navigation system. As for-some-reason elected captain it's my duty to make sure everything's in order. I notice that the wireless radio is not in its charger. We've been at port all this time with electricity available and it hasn't been charging. The battery shows that it's low, and it's not like we ever really use it anyway. It will probably be OK. I throw it back on the charger just for show. I grab the GPS and maps. The island the silversmith told me about is right next to ours, in the exact opposite direction of the way home. I look at the coordinates of each and think about which to plug into the GPS, which way to set our course. My parents don't know the difference between east and west half the time, they won't know the difference when we're sailing. I look at the island on the nautical chart and put my fingers to it like I could travel there just by holding the map. I feel the warm breezes and sand between my toes and ocean water around me like a mermaid. I let go, draw my fingers away, and the sublime moment passes. I look at the other island, closer to home, full of ending possibilities, everything coming to a close, the final curtain, moving on. What's next?

"Annika, come on up, we're ready to go! What's taking so long?" Dad calls from above deck.

My last few moments alone, it feels like I'm in Ariel's secret chamber in *The Little Mermaid* where she keeps everything that makes her feel alive. I take the GPS up with me and stand by the helm. Mom and Dad stand on either side of the main sail as we pull away from the dock, they rig ropes and make adjustments and test the wind. Cole unties the fenders from the side of the boat that served as a bumper against the dock. Everything goes smoothly as we sail away, my parents avoid using the power engine whenever possible, for a more authentic sailing experience they say. I look back behind me at the island as it wakes up from a delicious fairy tale dream, only I yearn to fall back asleep. It's a cold scary feeling to leave something you love. It's quiet as we make our way from port, we sail by beaches and bluffs and bountiful landscapes on either side of us. I want to run on the island, get lost in its heartbeat and build a secret world there. We sail out of the still secluded inlet, slowly being let out, like the long march of an army out of its kingdom and into another land.

It's a lot of time to make my decision, yet not enough.

Dad calls from his post and his busy-ness rumbling around the deck and below making sure everything's set. "Did you set the GPS? Are we good to hit the open water?"

"Yeah," I answer back. "We're good."

I enter the coordinates for the island with perfect shells, the island that lets me stay, the island that is calling me. I look in that direction and see a distant gray sky. I feel sneaky, and unsettled. My heart races with a sense of confusion. I'm surprised by what I've done, but think why shouldn't I? It could be an honest mistake. I talk myself out of remorse and a little piece of me shuts a door to anyone else. There's nothing wrong with doing what I want. Or as Mom and Dad would say, going after my dreams.

Chapter 4

It's smooth sailing. Mom and Dad are having an intense conversation below deck. They've realized the radio isn't fully charged. They're also trying to use new conflict resolution tactics that take the war-out-of-words. They aren't even paying attention to what's happening

above deck. Sometimes I think they trust us too much.

Cole is halfway-hanging off the side of the boat, he likes to see how close he can come to touching the water without actually touching it, and I'm sneakily charting our course in the wrong direction. I haven't even told Cole. Though he wouldn't notice something like that anyway. I relax a little. I'm getting away with it.

I decide to play a game in my head. I think of all the possible excuses to give when my parents realize we've landed on the wrong island. Do I confess my conscious decision? Or do I play innocent and say I got confused or that it was an accident? I imagine their possible reactions. The squirming, the lying, the deceit. Is that who I am?

Then Cole falls into the water, and I'm laughing harder and harder.

"Dad, you better come up here!" I manage to shout down into the cabin through my laughter. "Cole fell off the boat!"

We're not traveling very fast, and honestly this isn't the first time this has happened. "Man overboard! Man overboard!" I keep saying and I smile as Dad throws a rope out to Cole. He swims to the ladder mounted off the back of the boat. I keep our course steady. Even Cole laughs now, dripping wet and salty as he tries to give me a hug but I fend him off with a nearby net we use to fish things that should be recycled out of the ocean. Mom joins us at this point too and she orders Cole down below to change into dry clothes and to bring up *Wuthering Heights*. Mom and Dad don't seem mad at him at all. Actually, they look rather amused. They think it's funny. Maybe they'll react this way to me too.

"Why do we have to read this book?" I ask Mom again for the millionth time.

"Because you need to learn about love. What it is, and mostly what it isn't."

"Well, it's boring, and everyone is named the same thing, it's hard to follow. I'd rather read *Treasure Island* or *20,000 Leagues Under the Sea*. Why can't we read something fun and exciting?"

"This is a classic. It's good for you to read examples of actions and consequences, how selfishness can affect others, and what happens when you don't have boundaries."

Cole comes up with the book and Mom starts reading out loud. Heathcliff is obsessed with Cathy and puts all kinds of pressures on her. She's obsessed with him too but cares more about how others perceive her. I still don't see any relevance yet. But we humor Mom and let her read.

Dad is half listening and interjecting his thoughts on what it means to be a strong woman, and half preparing our lunch in the tiny kitchen. We usually eat cheese and crackers, apples, and carrots. That makes me feel like a reindeer. Mom and Dad try to be really conscious of the kind of food we eat and sometimes go to great lengths just to make sure we're getting all the right nutrients. One time we even grew and harvested our own algae so we could have living organisms without needing to eat yogurt. Sometimes we'll splurge though and have cheeseburgers, fries, and milkshakes. I wonder how I'll eat when I get to make all my own decisions. Or how often I'll actually clean my room or take a shower. Maybe I'll just go without rules for a while. I can't see the harm in that. Although, in that movie *Home Alone*, doesn't he get really sick because he eats tons of pizza and junk food? Or, at least, it makes me feel sick.

Dad makes his way above deck with our lunch.

"Look at that," he says. "Better eat fast before we hit those rain clouds up ahead." He swings from one side of the cockpit to the other on a rope like Tarzan.

I'm still dressed in my neon pink. It bubbles and crunches whenever I move. Cole makes up stories about how I'm the Bionic Woman and all my joint movements are accompanied by

sound effects. I think there is fog up ahead but I don't want to say anything to alert my parents. I don't want them to find out what I've done until the last possible moment. But should I really risk putting everyone in danger?

Mom takes a break from reading out loud while we eat. Instead, conversation turns to a review of our last year's adventure. Mom and Dad ask us our favorite parts, our least favorite parts, and what we learned from island life. We all laugh about the time Cole had to empty and clean the poop tank on the boat and when Mom accidentally bought ten huge rugs and we lined the inside of the cabin with them, like a giant furry intestine. Then we talk about all the things we had wanted to accomplish and how that turned out.

Mom and Dad started writing a travel book when we set out a little over a year ago, right after Cole and I were dismissed on our last day of seventh grade. They wanted it to be part-educational, part-memoir, and part-family counseling. It's not the first thing they're written together though. Sometimes they even do seminars on the books they write for couples and communication in the workplace. They say this is the one they'd really like to speak on though, to inspire Suits to find and live their dreams, to risk and invent adventure, to seek the fullness and joy of life in unconventional ways. They even let Cole and I write a chapter in each of their books. They really believe it's important to have a childlike perspective in the mix because they say it keeps them focused on what's important.

Maybe when I'm older I'll write some books. But for now I prefer to play in the sand and swim all day until I grow some scales. Cole is also quite the adventurer and we have some stories not even our parents know about. One thing they do know though is that Cole desperately wants some island animal to be his pet. A monkey really would have been his top choice but then he set his sights a little lower, even a small lizard or hermit crab would do. But he hasn't found a pet, and I haven't found the perfect shell I was in search of. Though, now at least I know one exists, even if the gypsy man wouldn't let me keep his. He did give me a charm right when we arrived on the island that I wear around my neck with some twine I found at the shipyard. It is a mermaid's tail split in two, kind of like legs. There's a small oyster pearl at the top where her belly button would be. He said it represents my journey from land to the sea. Part of me feels weird about it, but the other part keeps it as a memento of a fabulous year.

Then I feel the first drop of rain. It sets off a series of chain reactions in my mind that course straight down my spine. This could be the start of something bad. My heart picks up momentum waiting for someone else to notice the storm I am steering us into. Here we go. Why don't I just turn us around? Why don't I change direction? Why do I keep going?

Chapter 5

"Did anyone else feel that?" Dad asks. He starts to gather everything up from the cockpit.

"Yeah! Look straight ahead," Cole says. He points to one of the darkest storm clouds I've ever seen. It forms before us like news feeds I've seen of twisters materializing out of thin air in the dust bowls of Kansas. They form over miles and miles of abandoned or not-yet-claimed land, only this is the abandoned and not-yet-claimed ocean. Almost all at once the whole scene intensifies. Drops of rain turn into buckets of water. The ocean crests turn into lucid dinosaurs that rear their massive bodies above the sea level and plunge down into the depths, threatening to

take us with them, to turn us into another watery dream, to spin us into existence and then back out. But Anco is like a righteous man tossed about in any tempest, emerging stronger upon emittance. I only hope this one doesn't break her.

Dad quickly takes over command of the ship. He orders all the hatches battened, all life vests put on. I want to cry out inside for fear, but also for regret and shame. The only thing I can do now is ride out the storm.

Then I hear it, and see it. An electric bolt is thrown down all the way from outer space. Its crackling wires and sparks sound like you're at the dentist and hear drilling inside your head. It looks like the revolving fluorescent lights that burn your eyes at an amusement park as you spin around and upside down on thrill seeking rides. It smells like the burning of houses and lives and memories until there is nothing else to burn. Violins play ferociously with melancholia. Jason and the Argonauts, Odysseus, The Perfect Storm, Titanic. How I wish I had turned us around. I feel lost in a house of mirrors. I feel the horror of taking another step through a haunted house and deeper into the fear of the attraction, knowing there is still so much more to walk through. I have only just begun.

My parents have taken over. They look frantically and precisely at our weather proof charts. They wonder where we are. Rain obscures the printed words. They can barely communicate in the wind, it carries their voices away into the crashing waves, making them speak in tones carried up from the deep never meant to be heard above the stillness far below.

Through it all, the boat keeling on its side taking on water, with tears in the un-tearable sails, instruments fallen overboard, ropes cut into our hands and bellies, salt lacerations on our faces, the pain of opening our eyes to be filled with the howling harshness that forces them shut again, I see it. I see the moment they realize what I've done. The moment they know where we are. The moment they know we never should have been here.

I think, I am certain, I hear my heart crack under the weight of what I've cost us, it fractures a thin long line into my soul. But it is the sound of the mast, louder even than the elements filling all the empty space with their screeching. It splinters. It looks like a bayonet aimed at the sky, carried by a mighty hand in the wind. Then a giant fist crashes through steel, the mast disappears, swallowed whole into the hungry ocean. More dinosaurs climb aboard, stampede our boat. How much longer can we hold on? Is the rudder still attached so we can at least tell the vessel where to go? Where to stand firm in this raging opposition?

I see a whale sleek and leathery plunge in and out of the sea ahead. I think it is going to eat me and I will be in its belly until I go to Ninevah like Jonah. The Old Man and the Sea. The Black Pearl. The Albatross.

Chapter 6

Quiet. Not even the sound of birds chirping. Nothing. Slow. It seems I should not even move. There is sun again. A new day. We're on the island with the perfect shells. Yet, I would give anything not to be.

The mast is gone. The sails are torn to shreds, instruments lost to the sea. Dents, scratches, and chips abound. My treasured collection is scattered and shattered throughout the cabin. Bottles of sand, carefully sculpted driftwood, broken. Pieces. Gone.

When I get up on deck no one is around. It feels like one of those end of the world apocalypse movies and I'm the only survivor. It's so hot I'm already sweating. I sit in the

cockpit, curled up in a corner. I'm still waiting for something else to move. I don't even know what time it is. I am overwhelmed by the unsettling quiet. I can't sit still. Where is everyone? I crane my head around. It looks like we're in another dockyard. It must be far away from the cruise ship ports because there doesn't appear to be anything else around. I see the beach and jungle, mile high trees and white chocolate sand. There are only a few other boats around us, tied up to the well-worn docks, and a little hut with grasses all around and on top of it where the manager must work. There is a pink plastic pig on top of it too hiding in the grasses. No one is in there.

"Hello?" I call out from onboard and strain my ears, searching for a sound in the distance. My feet feel the little bumps on the surface of the boat deck like razor burn. I hop over the guard lines and onto the dock to get a good look at Anco. How is she still floating? So much work needs to be done. Even her name needs to be repainted. I can't imagine how long it will take, how long we'll have to stay here. I find myself excited for a moment, until I realize how much of this is my fault. Then I climb back onboard and wait quietly.

Panning the island, I imagine all the trails and hidden treasures that the lushness of the jungle must conceal. It calls me and ignites passions deep within to be wild and free and to roam secret terrain. The only thing that holds me back is fear of what my parents might say. I should probably be here when they get back, seeing as how we've yet to talk about what happened in the storm and maybe if I apologize right away they won't be mad or punish me. I sit and wait. Then I see them in the distance.

There's Mom and Dad, and Cole. But two other people are with them. There's an older man and a younger boy who looks about my age. As they get closer I see that the boy has raven black hair and matching eyes. His movements are quick and light. He balances on beams strewn across the ground and hops along the planks in the dock with some mysterious strategy. The older man looks similar with wet black hair, but he waddles along out of breath.

They all get closer but no one has said anything yet. Cole looks disappointed and sad. My parents show some stress in their usually carefree eyes, even behind their sunglasses. I look down at the sunlight reflecting off the metal accents on the deck.

"Annika, this is Mr. Howe," Mom says, introducing the man. "And this is his son, Knute. Mr. Howe owns the dockyard and is going to help us get Anco up and running again."

I look up but avert my eyes so as to not meet Mom's. Knute is looking at me, his eyes could swallow me whole like a snake. They are wet and watery, his eyes, licking their lips like the Big Bad Wolf. He squirms around, like it's hard to stand still. Maybe that's because he doesn't have any shoes on like everyone else and he keeps swapping feet on the sun scorched dock. He exudes quiet though too, like the island, like he is some kind of black hole that silences any kind of sound even before it's made. I don't know right away whether I like him or not.

"Annika, what do you say?" Mom is agitated. I've been distracted trying to read the boy.

"Oh. Hi. I'm Annika." I shake their hands over the guard lines. I get the same scaly-slithery feeling as before, but also feel intrigued by the sucking-in of Knute's eyes. It almost makes me blush until he lets go of my hand. The blood rushes back into my fingertips and I feel sweat form in between my fingers. They all look at the boat. Then, like the first kernel of popcorn popping in the pan Cole says, "I'm off to explore the island!" and he runs off jumping over whatever is in the way.

I think for a minute and then say, "Me too!"

But before I can jump over the side Dad says, "Just a minute young lady. You're not going anywhere today. Wait onboard until we finish the inspection with Mr. Howe."

I step back from the edge and sit down. My eyes dart to and from Knute, first embarrassed that Dad would say that in front of him, but then more cocky as I see a short smile of interest break the stoic command of his face.

I wait in silence, arms folded. What might have been a humble acceptance of punishment is now turned into pouting. They inspect and prod every aspect of the boat, but it might as well be me. They talk about numbers and days and technical jargon. It feels like they are speaking another language. I wonder where the beach of shells is on this island. I wonder how many there are. I wonder if it will be easy to find or how I'll even go about doing that. All I know is that I should be out exploring, not here baking in the sun and bored. It feels so unfair all of a sudden. Can't I just apologize and go back to my adventures? I see some of the debris left over from my collection that made its way into the corners of the cockpit. Pieces of me are all over this mess. I pick up some of the shells and look at their disfigurations. One perfect shell. I feel angry and throw the pieces overboard onto the dock wanting to watch them shatter even further.

That makes Knute look at me and I throw another so he doesn't look away. Then my parents and Mr. Howe come to an agreement. He and Knute slither off. My parents come onboard and sit across from me.

"Annika, what happened out there?" It's the first time we've spoken about it.

"I don't know. I put the wrong coordinates in the GPS."

"Did you do that on purpose?"

I pause before saying yes or no, I anticipate reactions to either answer. But the pregnant pause must be giving it away so I answer in as short a clip as possible just to get it out. "Yes." Maybe there's some hope for me yet.

They don't say anything. I can't imagine what they're thinking. They've probably already mapped out their responses to everything I could possibly have said so they just know automatically what to say next.

Finally Dad moves and starts to talk again. "Do you remember us telling you that we were heading home, away from the storm? We trusted you to navigate safely and correctly."

"Yes, I know you said that."

"You put us all in danger."

My heart sinks. "I know. I am so sorry." What a selfish thing to do. And that's all I can say?

"We love you Annika, but that is not OK. Your actions violated our trust, damaged the boat that's been our home, and almost severely hurt us."

"I know. I get it." I want to stop the list from getting any longer.

"The repairs will cost a lot of money. You're going to have to help pay for them."

Mom chimes in, "We've worked it out with Mr. Howe for you to help in the snack hut until the boat is ready to go again. You'll work there everyday from right after breakfast until sundown, which as you know is your curfew anyway. The only time you'll have on the island is when we're all together as a family."

"What?! You mean I can't go exploring now? We just got here!"

"No, Annika. That wouldn't be fair. Your actions don't garner that kind of reward. We'll all go out later. But for now, get ready and we'll go up to the hut to get you settled." The stupid pig on top of the hut is looking at me.

For the first time I feel like an emo-teenager. I try to shield my eyes with a panel of bangs pushed to the side, and a scowl stains my face.

I put on a really long t-shirt that says "Save the Whales" and short shorts hidden beneath

its length. My skin is nearly red. It's a layer of sun kissed warmth like clothing all itself. My cheeks look like hot air balloons strained towards the sky.

Chapter 7

Working in the snack hut is making me gain weight. I miss running and jumping and climbing and ducking, wandering and stumbling. So I've started practicing like those monks we saw on the previous island. I can't lift my whole body over my head yet but I am getting really good at sitting still. Especially at night when the sun starts to set and all I can see in the salmon pink sky are silhouettes of the palm trees, leaves like wisps of hair blown like wind chimes in the wake of a warm breath having whispered a secret. When night approaches I listen for how the ocean tells its story of a long day lapping the earth, continually giving kisses and affection to the sand between my toes, waiting for a response from its despondent lover.

Knute comes to visit me sometimes before it gets dark. He brings whole coconuts with straws and island games made with wooden and marble pieces. I bring the Shakespeare book and we read out of it. He always picks characters to read like Puck in *A Midsummer's Night Dream* or Iago in *Othello*. I prefer something from *King Lear* or *The Tempest*. But mostly I just like the sound of the words and the way everyone always knows exactly how they're feeling and are never at a loss of words to express it. It can take me a long time to just put words to my emotions in my own head let alone to communicate them with someone else.

This evening Knute said he'd come and bring us some instruments to play. Before he even arrives I imagine the little sounds we'll play breaking free into the sunset, notes as colors that paint the sky with splatters of saturation. They're the sound of my wild insides declaring their place, merging with the spinning world into night.

Here he comes. Wet black hair I want to touch. The things I forget when he speaks to me. He puts on some music from his hand-held radio and we play along with steel drums and pick out notes on a guitar. *Red Red Wine* and *Buffalo Soldier*. I close my eyes and smell salt and incense. The color turquoise comes out of strumming hands and tapping feet. When we sing I see the beginning formations of the universe and the yearning, quaking, in each individual grain of sand. There is something so much bigger than me. I know it. I feel it. I sense it. I see it.

Before the sun is completely gone and my parents expect me for dinner, Knute asks me about tomorrow night.

"It's been three months now, are your parents going to let you go out to the party alone?"

"No. They've already told me we're all going together."

"Well you should try to get away. I want to show you a really special place. We can watch the fireworks from there. And it's so cool to see everything from up above. All the costumes and dancing and all the food being made. You would really love it."

"I know I would. I hate being so confined on such a wild island. It feels like my eyeballs are popping out of my head and my fingernails are growing backwards."

"Ugh, that's gross."

"You tell me how it would feel to be tied to your parents' side or the snack hut all day all the time no matter what."

"My father puts restrictions on me like that all the time, but I just go off and do whatever I want anyway. That's how I met Chips."

Chips is his little pet monkey that he stole from its mother somewhere dark and

cavernous on the island. He won't tell me all the details but I think it involves heavy stones and sharp objects.

"I can't just disappear on them."

"Who says? Sure you can. Look, no one's even here now. Let's just go over there and walk back. There's a beach covered in shells. They'll never even know. Don't you want to see what's behind those trees and beyond the bend?"

I don't know if he's teasing me or taunting me, but yes. Yes I do. I think about it every day. I want to see the entire island. I want to stay and live here and be unchained all my life.

"Let me show you. You have a little while before you need to get home. I'll make sure you get back. Come on. It's not that bad to go. It's right over there."

He does have a good point. And I have been really good about staying at my post. I would like to see what's right...over...there.

"OK."

I tie things up at the stand and fumble over my flip flops. A rush comes over me and he grabs my hand as we weave our way out to the edge of the island. I see trees and unidentified shapes and reflections from the fast approaching moon that I've never seen before. New sand slides over my feet like waves. Even the weather, the air, the sounds are different over here. We are just rounding the bend.

"Annika! What are you doing?" My brother already beat us to it.

"Cole, don't tell Mom and Dad."

"Why are you with him?"

I look at Knute and wiggle my hand free.

"Come on, let's go," Cole says as he walks right between me and Knute and grabs my shoulder. "Stay away from my sister."

But Knute kind of smiles. "See you tomorrow," he says and slithers into the lush behind us.

"Cole, don't say anything to them OK?"

"Whatever, Annika."

We walk back to the boat just in time for sundown. I can't stop thinking about tomorrow night.

Chapter 8

The night of the festival I think of Baz Lurhman's Romeo and Juliet, Mercutio reciting the Queen Mab speech, psychedelic colors and dancers wearing feathers and masks. I pin my hair up and have Cole collect a few exotic flowers from nearby for me to weave through the mess on top of my head. Mom lets me wear some of her perfume and I smell like a bath of island frangipani, hyacinth, and birds of paradise. The flowers look like macaws perched on the nest of my hair. I wear a shell necklace from the gypsy man and a strappy dress I bought from a woman without any teeth on one of the last islands we visited. She told me this story of her seven kids and how they didn't have teeth either but how they help her weave and dye fabric into dresses and skirts and bikinis. She showed me pictures of them.

We all walk inland together. Mom, Dad, Cole, and I. Mom's skirt is flowing in the breeze and her opalescent blouse makes her look regal in the ever-setting sun. She and Dad are holding hands, her smile is so big, her lips so red, her teeth so white. Dad brushes her hair behind her ear.

Cole and I follow behind, starting to sense the rhythm of the distant beat in the soles of our feet and stepping to the music that travels through the island's veins and into ours.

It's quite a far walk along the main road to reach the inland. The road becomes darker as the sun disappears and leaves the stars to illuminate our path. Cole talks about a salamander he found and how he wants to take it as a pet but he feels too bad taking it away from its home.

The palm trees sway and add their rustling leaves to the music of the night which becomes more and more distinct, pulsing our veins for us. Strands of outdoor party lights appear, they connect trees to trees and shine the way to the festivities. When we arrive downtown there are bright bulbs suspended above the street in criss-cross patterns. There are smoky jalapeno scented clouds hovering over the sizzle of grilled meat and ice cold sweat-beaded glass bottles of local soda. There are chickens fluttering and clucking in the street. There are families laughing and smiling and yelling to each other over the drums and clapping and vocal harmonies. There is even a monkey on a revolving platform eating a giant pineapple! Cole and I look at each other and laugh as our parents say, "We told you so!"

There seems to be a constant stream of confetti in the air and bodies brushing by wriggling to the music. Now I know why the monkey looks so familiar! It's Chips! Knute and Mr. Howe are speaking privately behind the monkey, they appear to be arguing about something. Then Knute takes the pineapple that Mr. Howe is holding and thrusts it on Chips before storming off. Even from across the street I can see that he has blue lightning in his stormy black thundercloud eyes.

Pushing myself into his path I stop him. "Hi."

"Hey, Annika, come on let's get out of here. I'll show you that place I was talking about." He grabs my hand and I can hardly feel it.

"What place?" Cole asks, coming right to my side, almost being swallowed and carried off by the throngs around us. Mom and Dad are up ahead looking at carts of jewelry.

"Nowhere," Knute snaps and pulls my hand more forcefully, which takes me off balance.

Cole leans in to me as Knute leads me off, already gone in the sea of people save for our anchored hands.

"Annika, Mom and Dad said not to wander off tonight, we're all supposed to stay together! You've already gotten in enough trouble. Don't give them more reason to punish you."

What he's saying sounds true, but I barely have time to think about it before we're all shuffled around in the crowd. Tan, long haired, half dressed women and shiny glittery buff surfboard carrying dudes. Knute and I make it to the outskirts of the crowd and he heads in the direction of a rocky trail up the side of a nearby cliff.

"Come on, you can see everything from up here."

"Knute, my parents said not to." He slows down. The flowers are getting loose in my hair. I regain composure. "My parents said not to wander off tonight, that we're all supposed to stay together."

I think for a moment that he will take me back to them. Instead, he comes closer and takes both of my hands inside both of his. He makes sure he is looking me straight in the eyes and squints his eyes into slivered almonds.

"Did they really say that?" He stares intently. "Surely they want you to have a good time." Then ever so gently the pressure on my hands changes and I follow the direction they're being led. The music still blares in our ears. It makes shapes and colors appear in the blackness before us as we stumble up the rocky trail. At one point I think I feel a snake slither across my toes and island spiders between them. I have to take off my shoes to get a better grip as we

continue to climb. When I almost slip, Knute just pulls me closer, tighter, it almost hurts.

Then we arrive and we're really very alone together. He walks to the edge, what I think is the edge, it's too dark to tell. He breathes in as if the whole town, the whole festival, the whole island, are his and now I'm the only thing left to conquer. He was right though. From up here you can see everything. I walk closer to the edge, but not as far as him because I'm not sure of where I'm stepping.

"I think the fireworks are starting soon," he says.

I feel colder at the top up here.

"Maybe we should go back," I say, but he's hardly interested in what I've got to say. He keeps watching his territory like a gargoyle perched atop Dracula's Castle. I'm afraid I won't be able to find my way down by myself.

A firework shoots off and I jump. I look below and see the crowd turn their heads upward in unison. I feel guilty, like all their eyes are on me with the Scarlet Letter painted in the sky. Crackle crackle, fizz fizz, gold and silver, iron and bronze. I want it to rain down and cover me from this mess.

"Knute, we should go," I try again. I lean forward from where I'm planted so he'll hear me from where he is on the edge. Now his legs dangle over the precipice, where he sits to watch the sky. Another firework explodes and my voice is lost in its flames. He still doesn't turn around.

Before another arrow lights up the sky, I carefully and cautiously step over to him and tap his shoulder. He turns, almost fiercely, and grabs my hand away.

"Look, you're missing it!" He points to the sky. "I thought you'd be more fun."

The black night cracks open again in emeralds and rubies and beryl. It's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen. Glittering and glowing and interceding the night air. I want to breathe in their colors. I want to fit them all into the bulges of my cheeks like marshmallows. The night is lit and alive.

"Then go," I hear Knute say, totally uninterested in me anymore.

"By myself?"

"Yeah. You're the only one who wants to leave."

His voice feels like a vacuum that sucks the world out from around me and creates my own personal black hole. A firework missile explodes overhead. It lights up the sky and the cliff top, like it's another moon appointed just for me. I see in the tailing, shooting-star-light, that the ground is imprinted with the fossilization of beer cans and empty wrappers. They've been trampled so many times that they've become part of the landscape.

In the next flicker I also catch something in Knute's hand. It's small and white and his fingers run over it in bumpy patterns, like it's ridged.

"What's that?" The world comes rushing back in from oblivion, filling the void.

He smiles that smirky-half-lip smirk like the first time I saw him when my father reprimanded me.

"This?" He holds it up in front of his face, perfectly lit from every angle by the candelabras in the sky.

A shell.

Perfect.

Crisp.

Translucent.

Even.

“Where did you get it?” my interest pushes me on. I can’t leave without knowing.
“From the cove below, near the other side of the island. The one that man was telling you about.”

“Where?”

“Oh, I can’t tell you. You probably need to be going back to Mommy and Daddy.”

Now my eyes are slivered almonds.

In the next exotic peacock display from the sky, he turns and throws the one perfect shell off the cliff, waiting to hear it shatter on the pavement below, in the street where no one will notice the loss of something truly beautiful.

“Why would you do that?” I ask.

“Because. It doesn’t matter. I don’t. Nothing does.”

“Don’t say that. Mr. Howe really cares about you.”

“No he doesn’t. All he cares about is the monkey and making up stupid rules. He doesn’t even notice when I’m gone or know what I’ve been doing. He doesn’t care. I could do anything I want and he wouldn’t stop me.”

“Are you saying that if he stopped you from out all these times you’d know he loves you?”

“It’s stupid just forget it. Go.”

“Come on, don’t you want to....”

“Go! Annika, leave me alone!” We’re close enough now that he pushes me away and I fall back. He looks away and resumes his perch, hungry for the world below.

Chapter 9

Without thinking, I turn and take the first step down the cliff face. I can hardly tell where I’m stepping or what I’m stepping on. My hair tumbles down my back and leaves a trail of flowers behind like Hansel and Gretel, only I don’t mean to come back. Each time the night lights up I chart my course down the slope. I’m getting dirty and muddy and scratched but I don’t care. I just want to get back down to the street and find my parents. How can I explain this to them?

Spit out at the bottom of the pass, I am overwhelmed by the brightness of the candles and street lights after the absence of light in the brush. I adjust my dress and try to gather myself. How in the world will I find my parents?

I start walking and press into the crowd like the entrance to a labyrinth, but everything seems to be in slow motion. Laughing faces are wide open and clothing is flowing. Ice and heat are all around me. Sounds are slow and deep, I hear every footprint on the pavement. Every tooth hitting another. Every launch and lighting of the fuse that illuminates the sky. The music is slow and full of suntan oil, coconut, and island air. It wraps me in a cocoon where I’m safe until maybe I have wings to fly.

Then I see it, but at first I think it can’t be possible. How can it be? On the pavement, just ahead, I see it through the waving seaweed stream of legs flowing through the street. I get closer and bend down. I look up to spy Knute on the ledge above. I can only just barely make out his silhouette. Frozen. Impenetrable. Rebellious.

There is the shell he threw down. By my feet now. Still perfect. Whole. Complete. I scoop it up like a wounded baby bird. It didn't shatter on the pavement. It didn't chip. It didn't bruise or dent. And it's all mine.

Then, like a tape playing backwards in sticky rewind, the pace picks up, the lights flare again, sparklers stream through the crowd. I'm carried along, bumped and pulled. My eyes search and scan the crowd. I try to zoom in through the mass of people, but it's hard to see more than just what's in front of my face. Scruffy beards and crawfish and dreadlocks dance in the air.

I wonder what is going through my parents' heads. I wonder how they could ever trust me again. I wonder what they think of me. I must look really pathetic and selfish right now. It must look like I don't care about them, or love them. It's not like they were punishing me for the fun of it, or for their own enjoyment. But for my own good. I only got the proper response for my actions. Why would I get rewarded instead with freedoms, especially when I showed them how I can misuse it? They were only doing what's good for me. So maybe I should let them.

Then I feel a tap on my shoulder from one of the vendors. I close the shell tightly in my hand and make a fist. I turn around, frustrated that the search for my parents is now taking longer. "Little One! I thought it was you!"

I smile wider than in weeks. It's Rico, the gypsy man who told me about the shells. He's traveling with his silver and pearls. I see newly sculpted dolphins, mermaids, and endless waves.

"I thought you were going home?" His big tan belly is exposed through his velvet vest, laden with chains and jewels from the sea. They rise and fall on his chest with his words.

"I kind of made us take a detour," I say. "I wanted to find the island with the shells you told me about."

"Little One, it wasn't only this island. You could find one anywhere."

Oh. Genius. Of course.

"Well, did you find one?"

"Well, it was more like it found me." I open my hand to show him, like it's the most precious jewel or a little critter that might escape.

"It sure is beautiful," he says. "Now you can go home right?"

"Well there is one more thing I have to do. Have you seen my parents? Or Cole?"

"Yeah, they were headed over to see the monkey again. Something about wondering if it can tap dance too?"

"Thanks!" I say goodbye to the gypsy man for the last time and run off in that direction. I grasp the shell tightly in my fist so that I feel the ridges imprinting themselves on the palm of my hand. There they are! They're talking to Mr. Howe, and Cole is there. But I run up to them and above all the noise around us start to speak.

"Mom! Dad! I'm so sorry. I'm so, so, sorry. I know it was wrong of me. I know I shouldn't have gone off. I've been behaving so badly, when all you're trying to do is for my good so I'll bloom. I'm so sorry. I love you guys. I don't want you to think I don't because I didn't obey. It was so wrong of me and I'll do whatever you say." I hug them both and let go. Maybe love is keeping their commands instead of making up my own. They really do know what's best for me. And right now I really need that, because it can be so hard to tell.

Mom and Dad look at each other and agree that they forgive me and love me and that we'll all talk about this later.

Cole looks at me and says, "You knucklehead. Look what Mom and Dad just got me." He holds up the monkey.

"Chips! But that's Knute's," I say.

“Not anymore. Mom and Dad just sold our boat to Mr. Howe for a smaller one so we can get home faster without having to wait for all the repairs. He threw in the monkey too because Knute never takes care of it and Mr. How is tired of doing everything. Awesome, right?”

“Very awesome,” I say. Only I’m referring to going home.

Chapter 10

The sun makes me squint. It shoots off the cresting salty waves and the metal on deck. Our little cruiser is swift and furious. It takes ground in leaps and bounds across the surface, which conceals a world underneath. It is so vital to be back, jetting across the open sea. My hair is whipping and trapping the ocean spirit in my mane.

Mom is blasting Bob Marley. Dad is alternately studying the maps and charts that were saved from the chests of Anco, and navigating us out of the turquoise sea foam green waters. How I want to slip off the boat and swim in them one last time, grow a tail and gills, and live forever in the beauty of the deep.

Cole is shuffling his feet and trying to entice Chips to do the same in a somewhat tap dance fashion. The monkey is on a woven leash attached to Cole in case he falls overboard. Although, knowing Cole’s record, he’s the one we should be worried about. I wonder if Chips could pull him back onboard.

I take out Wuthering Heights and read the last few chapters out loud. Wow, that family went through some hard stuff. It makes me thankful that no one had to die in our family for balance to be restored. It only took the next two years of my life committed to working every Friday and Saturday night instead. I might hate it. But I can live with it for what I’ve done. And they said maybe I’ll get off for good behavior. I just want them to know I love them for wanting what’s best for me.

“Annika, look!” Cole calls me over to see what he’s got the monkey doing now.

“Hey, he’s doing a pose like those monks we saw on the island at the bazaar!”

We laugh and smile and wonder how in the world the monkey is staying so still with his little monkey legs over his head, all on a moving boat.

“Mom, we could make a fortune with this, look! We’d never have to go home!”

“Nice try, Cole,” I say to him.

As Mom comes over, I head over to the cockpit and snuggle in with Dad at the helm.

“Clear sailing,” he says.

“Yeah. Clear skies. Perfect for the journey ahead.” I nestle in, thinking back to the monks and the peace and stillness I was so envious of when watching them perform. I feel that now. Like inside there is a settledness about doing what’s right.

“Annika, I want to talk to you about something,” Dad says.

“OK, shoot.”

“Imagine your favorite flower,” he starts. “Maybe one from the island, or one that only blooms once every hundred years, or ones that open only at night and close during the day. Do you have it?”

“Yeah, Dad,” I wonder where this is going.

“Now, imagine that flower wrapped up tight as a bud. What would happen if you just started to pull the petals open on it?”

“Well, it would probably die. You can’t force it to open before it’s supposed to.”

“Exactly. You need to wait for it to bloom, from the inside, right?”

“Yeah.”

“Well, your heart is like a very beautiful and rare flower. I don’t want you, or anyone else, to be in a rush to pull those petals open. You let your heart bloom. It will. Just be patient. And it will be beautiful.”

“Dad, what’s this all about?”

“My little girl is just growing up. I want her to guard her heart when I can’t be there to protect it for her.”

“Thanks Dad. That’s weird. But thanks.”

“No problem,” he winks at me.

“Dad, what’s that in the distance?”

I point at a shimmer beneath the surface of the water. A froth, a bubbling, and a dark patch. I see another one. And another. A pod of whales? They are getting closer, and closer. Could they hurt the boat? “Dad!”

“Yeah, honey, I see them.”

“Aren’t you going to move? Get out of their way?”

“I’m trying to Annika,” he fumbles with the wheel and some sail lines. Mom and Cole come rushing back to us. But nothing is happening fast enough.

I know it’s not that common for whales to attack boats but it has happened before. I can only imagine what Mom and Dad would say being delayed again.

But the whales don’t hit our boat. They stop just short. They are breaching right by the side of the boat. My heart races. What if they land on our bow? They could sink our little ship. We all look around at each other and are too speechless to say anything, our mouths hang open. It’s at the same time terrifying and awe inspiring. Their bodies are so sleek, so massive, and yet so sturdy and weathered, leathered by and for the sea. They are so close I can see in one of their eyes. Its eyes are glassy twilight-black deep, only they aren’t as swallowing as Knute’s black eyes were. Instead, they are like doorways into the vastness of the universe. I keep thinking I’m looking at the night sky and half expect constellations to appear in the planetarium of its eyes.

The sounds they are making, even under the surface, I can hear them. They sound like a love beckoning, welcoming, and surrounding with light. I could dance to their music, it fires transcendence all across my brain in neon sine waves. I can understand with my feelings, and the bristling of my skin, everything they are communicating. It is like I am underwater and look up at the sun, my hair floating in the fields of golden sunlight.

Then the whales turn and swim away just as gracefully as they arrived. I look out to them like they’ve just turned my hapless heart upside down and made everything right side up again.

I smile at Mom and Dad. A sweet liquid joy seeps into my heart as I know they love me. We all stand together in the cockpit. Bob Marley ended a while ago and now all we hear is the wind in the sails and the effortless cutting through water, soaring on somebody else’s wings. I hear the sunlight painting the sky back to blue with a brush as soft as its rays. Cole even holds my hand and lets Chips climb on top of me over the bridge of our arms to give me a monkey kiss. He also pulls something out from behind my ear like a magician doing sleight of hand and I am too amused to be mad when I see that he’s holding my treasured shell. I snatch it back and give him a cross-eyed look that makes him smile a big monkey smile and do the same in return. He’s proving to be quite the quick study.

Then Dad speaks up. “Hey guys, Mom and I finished our book. You should take a look.” He pulls out a giant scrapbooking volume. It’s full of photos and scribbles and small souvenir

napkins and swizzle sticks, pink sand stuck to the back of packing tape, and postcards of brilliant sunsets and island vegetation. There are also pages and pages of text describing the islands, documenting our ventures, and discussing how to have a better relationship with your spouse.

Then Mom says, “Dad and I have been thinking. Since we’ve finished our book for our publisher, and now that we have Chips...”

Dad takes over, “What do you think of sailing the Mediterranean?”

Maybe Strength

Chapter 1

I am a hot mess.

Remember Punky Brewster and Uncle Henry? I'm pretty sure she never felt her heart strangled like this. It's as if I'm hooked up to a ventilator that's stopped working, oxygen that's carbon monoxide, and an IV drip of broken glass wrestling in my veins.

Two days ago I took the first bus out of town to wherever it was going, and the next and the next and the next. I don't even know what state I'm in anymore, the exit signs and city names swallowed by black holes in geography class. It all looks the same anyway and I'm waiting for something different. Somewhere with life in the air, cracking marrow-exposed bones, honey scented waters, and people who understand my assaulted heart. I'm waiting for what love really is, and growing up, and quieter things.

Xan, short for Alexander, thinks this is a waste of time. Maybe he doesn't know what it's like to miss something you can't even name, to need to see if there is anything left to hope for beyond our decaying detention halls. Or maybe he does but is afraid of not finding it. Maybe the absence of dreaming broke him, like so many others, chipped marionettes with loose tangled strings half-attached. I won't be like that though. I'm not coming back until I find something. If I come back. It definitely won't be empty handed. I'm not coming back to a world of absent fathers and broken hearts, promises of success and SAT prep, dying relatives and underage sex, uncertain dreams, anxiety, and hunger not for lack of food.

I met Xan in algebra. He always asks questions beyond my comprehension, then we go have pizza and he draws me pictures on the backs of napkins until I understand. He draws lines weaving time into existence on paper, eraser fuzz stuck to his fingers. Our favorite equation is pepperoni and mashed potato with extra cheese. I love to wait until it cools off enough to eat without burning the roof of my mouth, like when we used to dare each other to rip Scotch Tape off our arm hair. I like to think it shows discipline, self control, and resolve.

When I left, I gave Xan a detailed list of instructions. Before I board any bus I will let him know where it is headed and the rest stops along the way with calculation estimates for traffic and maintenance set backs. Methodical. Reliable. Then he is to call a pay phone at each stop and check in with me. If I miss a checkpoint he is to immediately come after me and only at that point can he let my mom know where I am. I don't think he will do this though, come through for me. He probably thinks I'm a strong girl and can handle whatever I get myself into.

But when I hear "strong" I think of dragging myself through another day of bipolar moments, one second hating everything about where I am and what I'm doing, and another compromised thinking it meets all my needs. Right now, strength is making it through another day to keep asking the questions until there are answers. If there are answers. Or one day will I become strong because of it? For this certainly doesn't feel like strength.

Strength is lions and courage and something that makes you not feel like crying everyday. It's the tree that only stands, not flailing in the wind, once it has roots and is grown, a warrior with a shield and a sword knowing what he is fighting for. I don't know why I go through this, or what is even worth the fight.

I came home from school three years ago in my freshman year, and my mom was sitting blankly on the couch with my dad. He asked me to join them. He explained that his job designing courthouses, jails, and prisons wanted him to move out west with headquarters and travel the world to find designs and ideas that could be implemented here. He couldn't do it from where we

lived and he didn't want us to come with him because he "loved us too much" to uproot our lives and didn't want to disturb anything. I think at that point in my life, if I had had any chance of becoming a giant steady oak tree from a twig of a sapling, this was the hurricane that pulled me out of the ground roots-and-all. He was supposed to shelter me and protect me so that I could grow over many years to become someone's favorite tree, like that green book with the boy and the tree on the cover. He was supposed to do so many things.

My mom and I didn't follow him. We moved into a small apartment and she continued visiting her mother everyday at the nursing home, telling her every story she could remember about her childhood until she forgot about the present. She would spend hours there and nights there, and I only saw her here at home sleeping some mornings on the couch.

I had wanted to leave many times. How easy it had been for him. I had stood at the entrance to my school, in the resounding ring of the bell calling me to homeroom. Listening to the death toll. Jangling coins in my pocket for the entrance to the underworld. Wading through the dead current of River Stix hallways and zombie bodies. Thinking I could go to class and dig deeper this well devoid of water. Or I could run. I could go, I could not look back. I could hide or drive or bike or fly. I could breathe fire on everyone who passed me by and be caught up in the transformation of the sky. Why did it always feel like there was no choice?

I wanted someone on a motorcycle to pull up and tell me to get on. I wanted a knight to rescue me from this, to call me on a great adventure. Then one day I thought, I could be waiting forever. I better go now. Alone. Just me. Deeper into the unknown. And that was it. No matter what the consequences, it would have to be better.

Now on the bus I wonder what my mom is thinking, when or if she even noticed I was gone. I wonder about algebra and what I'm missing and how long I think I might be away. I have five hundred dollars I took from my grandma's casino fund jar. Every month the nursing home takes them on a little visit. I have a chocolate bar and a book about philosophy, but mostly it makes me more confused. Who is right? What is true? Why is it so hard to figure out?

Chapter 2

We pull into the station on time, according to my calculations, and I get to the pay phone just as it starts ringing. We only have ten minutes and I know Xan is probably camped out in the boys bathroom, missing some class about ancient Greek civilization, with his stolen parents Zack Morris brick phone.

"You know what I learned today," he starts. "You should never eat a whole packet of mayonnaise on an empty stomach."

"Didn't you learn that last week?"

"No, that was mustard."

"Isn't it the same thing?"

"Well, I had to be sure. What if what you thought was just going to be the same, wasn't? Did you get my surprise?"

"I don't think so."

"OK, you'll know when you do. So when's the next stop? What's the next city? Tell me so that I can imagine whether my fetal pig is prancing around the sunshine state or Wyoming."

"Oh, I'm missing dissections, great." Part of me had wanted to know what it would feel like to slice through tough flesh, just so I'd stop wanting to. I tell him the location of the next rest

stop, some Indian name I can hardly pronounce. I still don't know my final destination. I asked the lady who sold me the ticket not to tell me so that I'll be surprised when I get there, and I hum to myself when they announce it on the bus.

"Are you doing OK?" Xan asks.

"I don't know. It's challenging. I mean. What am I doing?"

"You're running away."

"No, I'm not running away. I'm running *to*. At least, I hope I'm running to something."

"You're still running away from something else. A lot of people have it a whole lot worse than you and they're not being dramatic about it. They're dealing with it."

"I'm dealing with it too. This is me dealing with everything that doesn't make sense. But if dealing with it means ignoring it, or being strong means pretending I'm not feeling an ache inside, then I'd rather at least be in a real prison where other people can see the bondage too."

"Trying to be Houdini again?"

"Stop it."

"I know that this is important to you. I just don't fully understand it."

"You don't have to. You just have to let me look for something I think might be out there and then let me tell you stories about it. You just have to want me to figure things out. I just need you to still be there."

"I can do that. It's like watching 'The Good, The Bad, and The Ugly.' Sometimes I want to tell you not to do something, but maybe there really is some treasure you'll uncover and then I'll wish I went in with you in the first place."

"Yeah, my plan is to not come back until you're sufficiently jealous of all I've done."

"Hey I gotta go, that's the bell. Spanish class. I can't be late again."

"OK, bye."

"Hey, I miss you, Astoria. Please be careful."

"I miss you too." But I think he already hung up.

I look down at my ticket. It's greasy from my hands and all the road food I'm eating, making my way through every variety of potato chip. If I am looking for buried treasure I better at least know the places I'm already searching. I've never even heard of this one before. Final destination: Sandusky, OH, Middle of Nowhere, United States of America. At least now I know.

"Where are you going, Sugar?" a very tan lady dressed in an all white pants suit asks me as she sits down on a bench next to the pay phone to wait. She has gold earrings and platinum blond hair, very pink lipstick, and orange sun-wrinkles. I recognize her teased hairdo from my previous bus.

"I don't know."

"Well, what does your ticket say?"

"Sandusky."

"Well then, that's where you're going."

"No, it's not. Better not be. I'm just passing through, I mean."

"Now what if you were always just passing through? Wouldn't you get tired of living out of a suitcase? I'd rather unpack, fill the drawers, change my shoes, and explore the area. Maybe have a nice steak dinner or meet a mysterious stranger. Don't you just love the possibility?" Her accent is unrecognizable to me.

"No. I have other things to think about."

"Well, don't think too much, you might miss something important."

"Like meeting you?" I mean sarcastically.

“Exactly,” she drags out the ‘a’ sound. “I’m Miss Estelle.” Her teeth crowd her mouth like they are spilling out of her smile.

“Story. Well, my real name’s Astoria, but sometimes people call me Story.”

“I like that. But honey, you ain’t seen nothing yet. I’m from Sandusky and I have a friend who has a nephew who has a third cousin once removed who I’m sure could show you around and help you settle for a while.”

I’ve never called anyone ‘honey’ or even felt close to the urge to do so. I say if nothing else is going on, then sure why not. Though I have every intention that something else will be going on. Like the sun will be engulfing the planet, or there will be a nationwide clearance on panty hose.

“Say, that’s strange, we should be taking off by now,” Miss Estelle’s wrinkles relax. Her tightly held face deadpans. “Edgar! Edgar, go find out what’s taking so long.” She calls to a quiet looking man with Harry Potter glasses and graying facial hair, though he looks about twenty years her junior. Then to me, “We take this route all the time. Every time there is a little something to celebrate we get all dressed up and go to Atlantic City.” Her eyes light up like a suitcase-carrying starlet on Hollywood Boulevard for the first time. “You know there can be a lot to see in New Jersey. It’s almost like Las Vegas.”

“Almost.” I’ve lived there my whole life and it’s never seemed so glamorous. “What were you celebrating this time?”

“I found my passport after months of searching.”

“Why didn’t you go somewhere with it to celebrate? Isn’t that why you wanted it?”

“Oh, no, I just like knowing where everything is. That way when I need it the most I won’t have to look so hard, and I’ll be very glad I took the time to find it in the first place.”

“Is that your husband?” I ask about Edgar.

“Yes, it is, still treating me right after all these years.” Again, she lights up like her answers carry dopamine. “Come, sit next to me,” she invites and I sit down, by the way she leans in it sounds like this could be long. “He thinks sometimes I don’t see this, but at night when he can’t sleep he plays our wedding video and looks through our cigar box of memories. Only it’s an old fashioned film reel so I always wake up to the flickering against our bedroom wall. His favorite thing to pick out and hold close to his chest though is his gold lieutenant’s bar from the war. When in training they all had an image of the bar sewn inside their helmets so that every time they took their helmets off or put them on they’d remember what they were going through all the endurance of training for. Then when they finished they got the real thing. I know it reminds him of everything he hopes for and all he was coming home to when we were apart for so long. Then he’ll wake me up, as if I’m sleeping, and say, ‘I’d find you all over again, Estelle.’ And he holds me until we fall asleep.” The soft look in her eyes is so calming, as if one could be satisfied forever with an embrace. “What about you precious, anyone special?”

“Not like that, no. Maybe. I don’t know. It could be. He’s just my best friend.”

“There is no ‘just’ with a best friend. I don’t care who it is. You hold on to that person tightly, like your blood flows together. They keep the pieces for you when you start to crack so you can do something useful with them later. Your best friend is your incubator when you go through the trauma of hatching, and your cocoon when you become a butterfly.”

“Well, they can’t always actually be there for you.”

“It’s not about being there, when what you need is to be alone. It’s about letting you feel safe enough to become someone new when you need to.”

“Does Edgar do that for you?”

“Sugar, if he didn’t he wouldn’t be my best friend too. Now, tell me more about you, I just love hearing about hopes and dreams, especially for someone so young. How old are you?”

“Seventeen. And dreams are a waste of time, I have other things to think about.”

“These other things you think about must be pretty important if they leave no time to unpack where you are or to dream of where you’ll be. You must be thinking a lot about the past, poor thing, and it doesn’t look like it feels very good either. Like maybe you’re a nut that needs to crack while someone looks after your pieces for a little while.”

“Yeah, maybe.” I say quietly. But really I want to ask her more. I want to know how to do this, or not do it, or where to go or what to ask. It’s all swirling around inside of me again and I can feel the questions growing talons that scratch me from the inside out. “Have you ever? Cracked, like you say.”

She laughs and smiles. “Yes, dear, I like to do it regularly, that way I’m always fairly certain I won’t get stuck somewhere I don’t want to be, or should I say someone I don’t want to be.”

“Does Edgar do it too?”

“Yes, it just looks different for him. But there are a great many people who don’t and who never grow hungry enough to become a butterfly.”

“So you think I should keep going?”

“If you want to see what comes out of the cocoon.”

This lady.

“Well, I have good news and I have bad news,” Edgar says as he smokes a cigar up to Estelle and puts an arm around her with scrunched up love eyes. She wiggles in delight and smiles. “The good, our bus is still coming. The bad, the driver got sick and was throwing up all over the place so we’re waiting for it to be steam cleaned and for a new driver to hop on board.”

“Don’t they have another bus?” I ask.

“Who knows why they do what they do. I suppose they deemed it the best decision.”

“Great, now my schedule will be off and I’ll have to call Xan.”

“Is that the friend you were telling me about?” Estelle asks with eyebrows raised like my grandma used to do when we had tea and chunky jam.

“That’s him.”

I wonder about the things Estelle said. Maybe Xan does hold on to all the pieces for me, the ones I want to keep and the ones I want to throw away, so in case I make a mistake they’re not completely left behind. One time he dressed up as Einstein for Halloween and I went as a lightbulb. He always tells me that decisions are an opportunity to show what you learned from past ones, and he seems to know the kinds of jokes I like to hear when I’m down, and he writes me notes sometimes about why cannibalism is bad so I can make up songs about it.

“I’m going to call him,” I say. At least maybe I’ll be able to leave a message so he knows I’ll miss our next point.

When I get to the pay phone there’s actually a line to use it. I listen to a biker dude talking to his mother. He asks for advice about a girl and finally resolves to have her favorite flowers, and a medium size teddy bear, and a box of Belgium chocolates, delivered to her at work so she will know he is sorry for never telling her where he is going, with a note that says ‘I’m right here.’ Then a business looking woman with a wing pin on her jacket talks to an airline for a while before determining that they can’t help her locate her lost luggage even though she makes this trip all the time. Finally I hear a man on the phone with his daughter.

“Who loves you, Princess?” he says into the receiver, the silver channel swallows those words greedily. Or is that me?

“That’s right, your daddy. You’re so beautiful you know that? Tell Mommy I love her very much and I can’t wait to get home and see you guys. And you and me can have a special daddy-daughter date wherever you want to go, OK Sweet Pea? Yes, we can go ice skating and play Pretty, Pretty, Princess. I love you Sweetheart. Bye.”

I look at the man as he walks away from the phone and I think he sees the sadness in my eyes. My heart shuts up. My mind freezes. That could fall into the category of what I’m looking for.

I put money into the phone, still pondering all the words that man said to someone who will probably never know what it’s like not to hear them. I’m surprised when my coin comes shooting back out at me through the coin return. I try again and again and then use different coins and I’m getting so frustrated with the stupid machine. It finally takes my payment and the people in line behind me are looking at me like I have ten heads and my hair might turn into snakes. I dial. Nothing happens. I get my coins back and try again. Nothing. I hit numbers and the call end receiver. I want to cry. People are impatient. It’s not working. There’s no dial tone.

And then there he is.

The bus arriving to go to Sandusky, and my father getting off it.

Chapter 3

“What the heck are you doing here?” I want to yell across the station. I want to run up to him and beat his chest and rattle off a list of things I blame him for. I want to tell him to go back to the courthouse he designed and be sentenced to his own prison. I want to swear and be hugged all at the same time. But, nothing.

I want him to come to me, to be in control, to know what to say. I don’t want this to be hard. I want to run away. But he sees me. My heart races a mile a minute, my back sweats beneath my sweatshirt and I feel the coldness covering me. My stomach feels like it’s digesting acid and the memories of distant fights and lukewarm relationships enter my bloodstream like a drug having a fast acting reaction. It makes me silent, each thought battles to be the first out of my mouth. ‘You made me forget what it’s like to look at the world unhurt,’ or ‘Get away from me,’ or ‘I resent you because I think I’m supposed to love you and I don’t.’ I want to love you, but I don’t.

He’s in front of me now, looking, trying to find my eyes that are embarrassed and hard. It’s enough time to remember the only day we spent alone together. We went for a hike and I watched him navigate the mountain. Then we visited his parents and I ate mini chocolate easter eggs in their muted green house with the plaid scratchy sofa. Then we saw a movie, ‘Out on a Limb,’ and ate real movie theater popcorn with butter. At the time I didn’t know that would be the height, that would be the day to look back on. If I knew in the moment I would have asked more questions, I would have loved it a little more, or maybe he would have too. Now this, and we’re alone at some bus station with hundreds of people coming and going.

“There you are!” He says as if he’s been trying to find me. “We’ve been so worried about you!” He hugs me but my unresolve is a wall between us. “Are you OK? Do you have everything you need? Are you hungry? Why didn’t you tell your mother where you were going?”

She called me and said you ran away and must've learned it from me so I better find you. But here you are."

"Well, I don't want to be found," is all I can manage to say.

"Aren't you happy to see me?"

"No." Yes.

"I know there is a lot between us, Astoria, believe me. And we can talk it all out and I'll answer all of your questions, there's nothing I want to do more."

"Then why didn't you do it sooner?"

"I didn't think I could come back to you. I was afraid that each day that passed that I didn't do it was sealing the door between us more and more."

"It was."

"And I feel guilty. It was never right to do what I did. And I'm sorry I didn't come sooner."

You've got to be kidding me, is all I can think.

"Come on, let's get you a ticket and go back home."

"No," I snap, like a mousetrap as it tears someone's head off.

"Then I'll come with you, where are you going?"

"No." I pull away. "I'm doing something special and you're not going to ruin it. I'm looking for something and you can't help me find it." But I really want to say tell me everything and make me love you again and help me, help me, help me.

I walk away toward the bus with my ticket out. My eyes burn and I force myself not to turn around to see if he's following me. Almost everyone has boarded the bus and when the man rips my ticket I look back around. He's not there. I should've known not to expect anything more.

On the bus Estelle sees me and calls me to come sit near them. If she tries to talk to me I'll probably cry. There's an empty two seater in front of them and I sit in one with my backpack in the other so no one sits next to me.

"Did you reach him?" She leans forward between the two seats to get more personal.

"Who?" my mind races and I turn hotter than I already am.

"Xan, I think, that boy?"

"Oh, no, I didn't."

"Oh honey, you don't look very good."

Then I sink lower in my seat because my dad just boarded the bus with a newly bought ticket and I don't want him to see me, or I don't want to see him. But he does and he moves my backpack up above the seats and sits next to me.

"I'm not letting you go by yourself," he says as he sits down.

"You never cared before."

"I do now and I'm not going away."

"Honey, who's this?" Estelle says with an edge in her voice that I think means business.

"No one."

"I'm her father."

"No he's not." I look at him like he must have no idea what that word means, and then I look away.

"In that case, I'll leave you two alone," she says with an understanding and sits back to whisper something to Edgar.

We all stare out the window in silence when the overheard announcement comes on. "Thank you for choosing Peter Pan. We recognize that you have a choice and want to express our gratitude. Our travel time will be two hours and forty five minutes with our final destination Sandusky, OH."

"Why are you going there?" Dad asks me.

"Because that's what my ticket says."

He thinks for a moment. "If you're running away, why not choose somewhere you've always wanted to go?"

"First, I'm not running away. Why does everyone keep calling it that? And second, there's nowhere I really want to go, I don't care and it doesn't matter."

"Then you could have just stayed home, you know. And whatever happened to California? I thought you were dying to get out there, to see the big Hollywood sign and put your hands in the prints at the Walk of Fame. You wanted to see Grauman's Chinese Theater and the canyon and the farmer's market."

"That was three years ago. Things are different now."

"You wanted to make movies and buy a video camera and go to film festivals and NYU."

"Did I?" stoically, as if he were knocking on a door to which I had long ago lost the key.

"Yes, you did."

Many times I had wanted to cry out like Maria at the end of West Side Story, "Chino, how many bullets are left in this gun? How could you shoot all my dreams and not leave a bullet left for me?" It was very painful business, dreaming. I wish he hadn't brought it up.

"Oh you want to make movies?" Estelle squeals from behind us. "So sorry to interrupt but that's so exciting. Of course, that's your name isn't it? Of course, you should tell your own story."

"There's not much to tell."

"Sure there is. Just tell about what's going on now. Here, we won this playing BINGO. I have no idea how to use it." She pulls out a brand new video camcorder. I look at it almost mystified, as if being entrusted with a great and purposeful responsibility. Here I am between my dad and a dream not knowing much about either of them.

"OK, Estelle," I say turning toward her and turning on the camera, view finder up to my eye, trying to make my dad disappear. The cool sensation of metal to flesh reminds me of my favorite directors and story lines and making sense out of chaos. "What did you want to be when you were growing up?"

"Oh that's easy," Estelle says. "I wanted to be an astronaut, to wear those big puffy suits and eat the dried out ice cream. Then I wanted to be a postmaster because I don't think I would like spending so much time away from my home to be in space, and I liked the idea of bringing people good news and letters from friends. But then I realized I would mostly be delivering bills and magazines and coupons and I moved on to want to bake cookies. That's how I started my business of baking and selling cookies from my grandma's secret recipe to everyone in our town."

"That's a big difference. Being an astronaut is a huge dream and selling cookies is so small." This is disappointing.

"Who's to say what is big and small? There were things I didn't want to give up and things I learned were important. Being an astronaut became a dream that would have been so small and making cookies became so big. Besides, it took awhile to understand my heart. It was

quite a journey. What do you want to be?" She takes the camera from me and gives me time to think.

"I don't know. I want to find what I'm made for. If I'm made for anything? I like math and I like movies. But I don't know if that matters or I should just work for an insurance company or get a retail job selling other people's things."

"What? No," my dad pipes up, as if fighting for some part of me that has been captured or lost. "You go after that. Don't you settle. Don't you think it's too hard or too much work or will take too much time. The time will pass anyway. Sure it will be hard and you'll feel like you're on your own in some wilderness, but you have to push through and go claim it. That's what was put inside you. Don't let yourself be cut off from it. Even if you're not sure, go in that direction and see if it's right."

I am shocked and don't say anything, I wonder if he'll say more. His eyes look almost fierce. His heart almost tangible. Why is he doing this now? Why is he trying to play the hero in the story where he is supposed to be the villain? Why now, at this time, when I'm finally doing something for myself?

"Story, I left too. I know what it's like to run away and to be scared. To want things you don't even know about. I know what it's like to be lost and to want all the answers. I did the same thing as you."

"I'm not running away."

"I found the answers. And you can too."

"Why did you leave?"

"Do you really want to talk about that now, here?"

"Yes." I say, thinking it will be easier if other people are around. Then we hear the camcorder tape click like something getting stuck. Estelle bangs the side of it and motions for us to continue.

"Nothing made sense anymore. I didn't know why I was doing anything. Every day it got worse and worse with no end in sight, so I thought I should do something drastic to break out of it."

"Like a mid-life crisis?"

"That I wish I had had a long time ago when I was younger. I think of all the time it would have saved. Even though it looks like nonsense to a lot of people, I'm really proud of you. These answers lay the foundation for the rest of your life. Can you imagine not taking the time to find them? Never knowing later what you stand on and how you got to where you are? Plenty of people don't even think about these things. But look at you. All anxious and fed up with life, wondering if there's ever going to be anything more. I am so proud of you for seeking, with all you have and all your heart."

"Really?" I had never thought about it like that before. How did he know about all that inside of me? How could he have experienced the same thing? My heart feels softer before him. The least likely person, the one understanding me better than anyone else, my father. I feel a sense of relief, in some small way, to not be walking a path that's never been walked before, to have some part of me known and seen by someone who knows what it's like to have been here. Who seems to have made it through with a bit more understanding and resolve, who doesn't make me feel crazy for hoping, who shows me there is something to hope for. And all this from my dad.

He continues with more to say, "When I left it wasn't really to take another job." He stops, anticipating my reaction. But I give him none, I think I knew that without him even having to say anything. "Any reason I could have given wouldn't have made sense to anyone."

"But you had responsibility, you had a family. You can't do things like that. You should have done it before or done something else. At least I'm doing it now."

"I know, it was never right to do that to you. Story, I am so sorry. Would you forgive me? I want to make things right again."

I thought it would feel different to hear. I thought my walls would come crashing down. I thought it would be like in the movies. I thought we'd hug or someone would cry. But then the camera beeps and a red light blinks. We both look away from each other and at Estelle.

"Sorry, sugar, end of tape. Why don't you keep going," she whispers.

But I am afraid the moment is lost and afraid I can't bring it back. I see us pulling into a rest stop and it's raining now, filling the sky with gray and vicarious tears. The bus driver makes some announcement that sounds like adults on Charlie Brown, muffled and distant, unimportant, and irrelevant. People start shifting and getting off the bus, finding umbrellas and plastic bags.

"Maybe we should go, Dad. Let's go."

"Oh you want to get off?"

"No, I mean go, like to California. I mean, if you want to come."

Immediately, I think of the time he took me to a magic store. I had just seen my first magic show, David Copperfield, and before that had no idea that things like coin vanishes and linking rings and disappearing ladies and flying existed. I found and read books about Houdini and Doug Henning, studied sleight of hand, and tried to put on my own magic shows. All of my friends said they knew how I did it. I didn't show tricks to anyone anymore after that. I had read about the Magic Castle in Los Angeles, where all the magicians perform and you have to be part of a secret club to enter. Maybe we could go there. Maybe we could do a lot of things in L.A.

"Yeah, let's do it," he says. Dad actually used to live there. He told me stories at night before going to bed about the beaches and the boardwalks, about the sunsets in the west. He told me stories about going to school there and meeting my mom at prom. He told me about lemon trees in their backyard and the cafes on the ocean they would go to. With all these associations L.A. seems like a very magical place. I think for sure I could write a movie there, or Xan and I could solve long and complicated math equations. I could have a vespa and live on a canal in Venice. I could take yoga classes and never just eat chocolate for lunch. I could eat sprouts or avocados or pomegranates. Maybe L.A. could be the answer.

"I can buy tickets when we get to Sandusky," I say.

"How much money do you have?"

"Enough," I say, but I know he wonders where I got it from. "I took it from grandma's casino fund," I have to confess under the weight of my father's eyes.

"I have a better idea," he says. "Come with me."

Chapter 4

My dad gets up from his seat and lets me out into the aisle. "Grab the money," he says.

"It's in my bag," I point overhead.

He takes it down. "That's heavy, what do you have in there?"

“Just some books,” I say as I rummage around for the envelope with the cash, feeling a rush of adventure. My hand comes across something I didn’t know was in there. I wonder what it is. It feels like a text book wrapped in a brown paper bag, the edges are definitely worn and I take it out. I open the front cover. It’s from Xan!

Story, I hope you find what you are looking for. Either out there or in here, Xan.

It’s his old written-in calculus book. I put it away for later. This is definitely the surprise he was talking about.

“Come on,” Dad says with excitement in his voice, already ahead of me and down the aisle. I grab my stuff and go.

Outside the bus is Ernie, our Puerto Rican bus driver. He’s smoking a cigarette and squinting in the rain under his hoodie. He reminds me of tacos and sunshine.

Dad whispers over to him, “Hey man, do you think you could help us out? See we need to get to California and this bus is going to Ohio.”

“Yeah, you can get a bus there.”

“I need something a little sooner than that,” Dad says and motions for my envelope.

“How much sooner,” Ernie seems interested.

“About,” Dad leafs through the bills, “about four hundred dollars sooner.”

“Let me see what I can do,” Ernie says, letting his cigarette fall into a puddle before waddling off across the parking lot.

I can already see surfboards and palm trees. I can taste chili dogs and date cakes, things I think I’d eat if I lived in L.A. I can smell the ocean and suntan lotion and air conditioning. I can hear cars backing up on the freeway and radio signals piping Bob Marley and the Beach Boys into the always sunny sky. I can feel the air there holding me in its warmth, telling me everything’s going to be OK, that I have a destiny and that all my days are preordained.

But then I look around the decrepit parking lot and see people running inside away from the rain. I hear freight horns and rumbling on the nearby highway. I taste smoke and wet in the air, and smell fast food rotting in the dumpster. It makes me feel cold, alone, and undesired. We can’t get out of here fast enough.

Ernie waddles back to us and I wait for his smooth accent to bring good news. “Sorry man, can’t do it.”

“Well, here, what about this?” I say holding up Estelle’s camera instinctively without even thinking.

“Hmmm. Let me check,” and off he goes again.

“What about your story?” Dad says.

“It’s the past. Probably wouldn’t hurt to let it go,” I say and sort of smile.

Ernie comes back, “It’s a deal, get everyone back on the bus.”

Once on board, Ernie makes an announcement like a safari tour guide, “Listen up, we’re changing some things around. This bus is now headed to sunny California, home of the movies and Mexican food. Anyone who still wants to go to Ohio can get out and board that bus over there, my friend Oscar will take great care of you. Otherwise if you stay on this bus you have one non refundable one way ticket to paradise. The bus leaves in exactly two minutes, so make your decisions and gather your belongings fast, Oscar runs a tight ship over there.” He winks in my direction and I see a shiny gold tooth. There is definitely something pirate-esque about him, like maybe he’s done this kind of thing before.

I certainly hope so.

Only a few people remain on the bus, including Edgar and Estelle. I tell her about the video camera but she says it's OK. I also tell her how we bribed the bus driver. She says that's the most exciting thing she's encountered since Atlantic City and she knew I was going to be the cause of some great adventure. We look around the bus and see a young couple trying to sleep on each other's shoulders, an elderly woman at the front of the bus, and a teenage boy and his mother behind us, they look like they are on a homeschooling field trip.

The bus pulls out of the rest stop and I think about how much has changed since I left home a few days ago. At this rate, maybe I'd never go back, not now that I have this new sense of being able to do what I want, when I want. I'm missing a history test today, a science review, and the cheerleader's bake sale, not to mention a walk or two down the hall with Xan listening to his outrageous stories about stumping the teachers or exploring lost corridors.

I look at my father out of the corner of my eye, I don't want him to see me staring. He is young, not clean shaven, and wearing flannel. It looks like he rolled out of bed and bought the first ticket out of wherever he was. Like he didn't hesitate. Like he knew I needed him before I could ever admit it or find it out myself. Like it didn't matter if I knew because he did. My dad. My dad came for me and now we're going on an adventure.

"I forgive you," I say, almost uncertain. Lifting my eyes breaks the dam and a clear stream of the purest love starts flowing its tributaries into my heart, while the hurt and anger it replaces gets further and further away like an old house at the end of a dirt country road that you are riding your bike away from.

He hears me and takes my hand and squeezes. The palms of my father are big and warm and safe. They remind me of walks in the park and looking up at clouds in the meadow, and David Copperfield flying. He lets go and I think maybe he will do it again sometime. That would be OK with me.

Chapter 5

I remember the book that Xan gave me and pull it out of my backpack to look at on the long drive. As we travel, the sun breaks through and gets on the bus with us. It warms the brown paper book covering so I can smell it and remember the new beginning to each school year when all my books would be prepared this way for the year to come. Like a mummy preserved. I open it and start at the beginning, like Genesis. I imagine much of the book won't be as impressive unless I start from there. I might miss something important that could change the meaning of everything further along. If I were a mummy I'd want someone to unwrap me and try to bring me back to life.

What I like the most are Xan's notes in the margin. They ask questions of the text and then work out the answers in some inspired way. His writing looks like spider webs and candy trails spiraling through the bridges of other letters. I wonder if it is cheating to not figure it out on my own. Though there will still be plenty to figure out once I get beyond this, so for now it's a good start to understanding.

I fall asleep for a while and when I wake up we're driving through the desert. Blue and gray thirsty skies. Every now and then I see a cactus or a rusty road sign as parched as the rest of the landscape, revealing how many hundreds of miles it will be until we see something else. I can sense California getting closer and closer. I relax in my seat and feel a bit of disappointment slipping away. Maybe I have been starving it to death.

I start to hear some whispering around the bus and heads crane to squint out the front window. Their voices die down but each time we pass a road sign I hear them again. I ask my dad to let me out of our row and carefully walk up to Ernie at the front of the bus.

“Hey, what’s going on? What’s everyone whispering about?”

“So you’ve noticed. Well, they’re all seeing the mile markers to Las Vegas. I’ve been hearing some very desperate pleas to make a stop through. I wouldn’t mind it myself.”

“Oh,” I say.

“Why don’t we take a vote,” he suggests. “You’d really make a lot of people very happy. And if everyone wants to go it’ll just be a quick visit, maybe stay a day or a night.”

Ernie’s smooth talk sounds sensible and reasonable and why shouldn’t we go if everyone wants to. I guess we could take a detour, it’s not like I have a time limit, and this is supposed to be an adventure.

“OK,” I say, giving him the go ahead to take a headcount. Six to four, Las Vegas wins. Only Dad, Estelle, Edgar, and I vote no. I look back at my dad and our new friends, feeling embarrassed and compromised.

How could I so easily change direction? I lose balance as the bus veers to the left dodging an enormous tumbleweed that came out of nowhere, and then veers to the right taking the first service road to Vegas. Our path behind us clear and straight and laid out to California slowly fades as we make our way down this new one, older and more worn and full of potholes with patches of dirt road and then concrete. I try to not let disappointment back in. I resist not liking this at all.

I sit back down with my father. “What happened there, kid?”

“I don’t want to talk about it.” Everything I felt before is threatening to show up again, and I want a new way of dealing with this, not like I’ve always done.

“Honey,” Estelle says, “maybe you’ll find what you’re looking for there? Sometimes it shows up in unlikely places.”

I want to not like Estelle because her outlook is so positive and I don’t know how to have that.

“Excuse me,” I say to my father as I get up again, I just can’t sit still. I take Xan’s math book and go to an empty row where I can sprawl out and be alone. A few minutes later he comes over to me and sits in the row in front of me and talks to me over the top of the seats. His flannel shirt is starting to annoy me.

“What are you doing?” he says.

“Calculus.”

He’s quiet for a while and then says, “Why?”

“Because it calms me down,” I say, still feeling frustrated. “It focuses my mind so I don’t think of other things. And it reminds me of things that are true. X will always equal X and you can never divide by zero.”

“That makes sense,” he says. “Is there anything in there about staying on course?”

“Dad, that’s what the whole book is about. You can’t solve an equation without actually solving an equation.”

“And you can’t get to California without actually going to California.”

“We’re still going. We’re just taking a longer way to get there,” I say defensively.

“I know, I just don’t want to see you give up on something because it’s what other people want or because you think it won’t really matter. Sometimes all you know is what you’re holding onto and when you let go there’s nothing to bring you through the unknown. Remember when

you were little and you and your friends would string rope all around the backyard and through an obstacle course, then you'd take turns being blindfolded and using the rope to guide you through the course? It's like that. When you let go you don't know where you are or how to get out of the maze."

"When did you get so wise?"

"When I left and didn't know how to get you back."

I look down at my book. "Would you leave me alone for a little while, I really like my own space."

He's struggling to not reach out to me and backs away.

As we move toward Las Vegas I wonder if maybe I could want that instead. The constant fluorescent light, the glamor, the sizzling heat. Maybe it's just the same. Maybe it doesn't matter where I'm going. Maybe I've made it far enough.

I look out the window and see endless stretches of sand. It brings to mind rattlesnakes, and scaly lizards, and aristocratic women complaining of the heat and removing their corsets. I think, 'Thank God we're only passing through.' But then I wonder who is God and why do I feel the way I do. I'd rather thank him for something better than just not being left in the desert.

Then I hear and feel a loud screeching sound and Ernie regains control of the wheel as the bus skids across the road and halfway into a low lying ditch. Everyone is OK but emotionally stirred up. They mumble and murmur checking in with each other as we file off the bus to see what happened. In the middle of the road is a half dead porcupine. Its blood is starting to flow out of a rupture and I think it must be very painful to die. There are also remnants of spilled cargo in the ditch by the side of the road. Dismantled boxes, wood and nails filling up the hole. We drove right into a land mine for tires, which are currently deflating.

"No, no, no!" Ernie calls out and starts speaking sweet Spanish words to his bus and stroking its hubcaps.

"Now what do we do?" one of the passengers says. "I can't believe we came out here with you. It would have been better to just go where we were going in the first place." They all agree. "It's nearly forty miles to the next service station. We don't even have anything to eat or drink. Look what you got us into."

"Hey everyone, it's not her fault," Dad says standing next to me. I've been liking his sense of being a protector. "Why don't we just start walking and see if anyone shows up driving down this road."

"We haven't seen anyone else for at least fifty miles," another passenger says. "Aren't there spares on the bus?"

Ernie looks up from his embrace and stares wide-eyed, "Yea, they're already on the bus."

"OK everyone, only take what's important to you and what you can carry. Definitely leave your luggage behind. It's hot out here and we might be walking for a while." Maybe Dad does make a good leader.

I can already feel the sweat beading on my forehead and we've only been outside less than ten minutes. I wonder how Edgar and Estelle will hold up under the heat. They can't possibly be OK with this. I look over at them and see them leaning on each other whispering. Some people get back on the bus to grab their things but for the most part no one wants to be stuck carrying anything. I take my backpack.

I notice that I feel scared. I think I shouldn't have even tried to come here. What's the point? What am I really going to find? And now I'm lost in the middle of the desert having to walk somewhere I don't even want to go. It's a good thing Dad is leading this expedition.

Otherwise I would be inclined to sit on the bus and wait to become a desert skeleton, or to be eaten by coyotes, that might be more exciting.

We start walking and already I feel too hot to move. Giant rocks are starting to look like creamy scoops of french vanilla ice cream, and the horizon ahead like a ballet bar in front of me. All of a sudden I feel like I did at my third grade birthday party. We had roles and roles and roles of toilet paper and we took turns wrapping long sheets around everybody to make them look like a bride in a wedding dress or a bandaged up mummy or a fairytale princess. Everything around me started to close into a pinhole and I knew I wanted to sit down. I also felt that way in tenth grade after eating a bunch of mini cinnamon doughnuts after giving blood for the first time.

For a moment I remember being in school, the gnawing feelings of wasted time and dreams left behind, or malnourished. I see the captain of the track team, the A+ biology student, the members of the jazz band. The crepe paper hallway decorations, the locker posters on your birthday, and the popcorn chicken in the cafeteria. I hear the P.A. system clicking in static and feel the pressing crowd around me trying to get to class on time, the naked arteries of the school clogged with teenage cholesterol. It's overwhelming, impersonal, and suffocating. It's this heat and this desert, everything I ran away from and nothing I was running to.

And then the frustration flips a kill switch and my consciousness shuts off and I welcome the catch of the sand.

Chapter 6

I wake up to the desert telling me that nothing matters but dusty bones and silence embroidered with the crack of ravens. My eyes open and I see the heat in the sky. I feel glued to the ground so firmly that even my chest has a hard time rising away from it just so I can take a breath. There are more people around than I remember. I don't want to see any of them.

"Story, Story, honey," I open my eyes up to see Estelle by my side telling me to get up. Shouldn't she be the one this happened to? "These nice men have stopped to help us out. They're on their way to Vegas too and can give us a ride. You'll be much more comfortable in their van, there's air conditioning."

You've got to be kidding me. Then I see three short and stocky men high fiving Ernie and punching each other in extended greetings. They look like a cross between the Three Stooges and Roman gladiators. They also remind me of pirates. One of them is actually wearing an eye patch and a bandana tied around his head. I can't understand a word he is saying even though I think he is speaking English. Everyone else seems to think this is a good idea and have already gotten into the van. It has tinted windows. I hate small spaces with so many people. I long for my own space, a secret place to call my own, where I can figure things out and whisper what I know and become the girl I'm meant to be. I can't find it out here.

In the van I think for sure we're all going to die. It feels like being squished into the runaway railroad car at Thunder Mountain in Disney World. Only now the billy goats and prickly pears are real.

I miss Xan.

The ringleader starts leading everyone in song out of pitch and off key. "Yo ho, yo ho, the pirate's life for me!" Why do they know all those lyrics? "We pillage, we plunder..." followed by, "Fish and chips and vinegar, vinegar, vinegar." Even Dad and Edgar and Estelle have joined in. Like they're all having fun.

Then behind all of their hooting and hollering I start to see the giant rising out of the desert. Even from far away it lures like a sleeping dragon, a craggy rock of sirens, like an oasis that's only a mirage. It makes you think it is regal, majestic even, laid with opals and pearls. There are very tall palm trees and glass buildings, a strip with everything you think you could ever want on it, enough to make you stay and never leave, thinking shouldn't this be enough? But you still feel empty.

We enter the city where they hand out collectible porn cards on the streets, where you can see the Statue of Liberty and the Eiffel Tower at the same time, and where live entertainment is the screaming pulse of life. I am mesmerized by the shooting fountain outside the triumphant Bellagio hotel, the pillars and strength of the Venetian, the gemstone green of the MGM Grand that reminds me of the Emerald City in the Wizard of Oz. Does that make me Dorothy? And wasn't the wizard a hoax? Well if this is my Emerald City at least I have my Tinman, Scarecrow, and Lion with me. I look at Dad, Edgar, and Estelle. I might still be wandering the mass transit system if it wasn't for them. I can't wait to all get to L.A. together. Maybe we could stay for a while and try living life there. Starting over. Fresh, and new, and un-messed-up.

We arrive and stop in front of Treasure Island. I practically crawl over people to get out of the van. But I'm stopped because one of the huge men isn't letting people out. He's making them hand over their valuables before they can leave. I see him show a knife just to look threatening and everyone gasps. It's only then that I realize all the bags in the back of the van were looted from our broken down bus. Dad tries to make a scene but then he sees the knife too. They take my backpack and my book from Xan. My anger feels trapped in my body, like it is scorching the inside of me. Like too much hot pizza on the roof of my mouth. I wish I had never come here. Look at the mess I've gotten us all into.

Outside of the van I go over to Ernie, "Let's figure out a way to get back out of the city and on to L.A." I say.

"Ah, chica, no can do. I'm with these guys now." He drags heavy on the end of his cigarette. I hope it burns his fingers. "This is the kind of score I needed to be one of them. Thanks, chica." He gets back in the van with his pirate thugs and they screech away, guns blasting to the sky if they had them.

Here I am surrounded by a bunch of angry companions, stranded in the city that will ravage us if we stand still long enough. "I'm sorry," I say half meaning it and half unjustified. They glare and disband under new direction talking about calling their lawyers and credit card companies. But they're seduced by the city and soon find themselves pulling out emergency cards and running to slot machines and love boutiques and ATMs.

Night comes and the Nevada sky is glittered pink with palm tree silhouettes. The mechanical fountains go off according to schedule and the actual staged pirate show starts behind us.

Estelle takes my hands and rubs them with her warm ones. She traps the air inside of mine. I can feel the bands of her gaudy rings. "Honey," she says, "this is all a bit too much for Edgar and me. We usually need some heavy medication to run off doing things like this." I want to crawl into her tender smile and live there. She pauses and I look over at the cannons firing to try and force the forming tears back into my eyes. Then she says it, "We're going home."

Edgar comes over. I knew they had been talking with Dad when I was talking to Ernie, but I thought it was about how to get to L.A. Then Edgar speaks after being silent a very long time.

"I want to tell you a story," he says. His voice is like roasted marshmallows. "One day all the animals in the forest," he starts and I interrupt.

"Is this a story about talking animals? I hate stories about talking animals and creatures who are like humans but painted blue. Just make them people." I just don't want to get too attached. He's leaving.

"Story, shut up, I'm trying to tell you something." He reminds me of my Italian American heritage and eating meatballs in sauce from the pot. Also olives and lazy lemoncello afternoons. "All the animals in the forest got together and decided to make it easier to raise their young by bringing them all together and teaching all the skills the creatures could possibly need to everyone. It would be much less complicated than dividing the group or specializing in anything. So they had courses in swimming, running, flying, and climbing. The duck wasn't very good at running so they made him work extra hard at it. But his webbed feet just got bruised and soon not only did he not improve by much in running, he had gone down a few marks in the other categories as well. He used to be top of his game in swimming but now he hardly had time for it. The rabbit could have been amazing at running, but he had to work so hard at swimming." He smiled softly at me with his eyes. I want to crawl into those too. "Take heart, Story, you'll find the way. It might be right in front of you, waiting for you to believe it."

Then it's Dad's turn. "I've been thinking," he says, "I should probably go with them. Make sure they get home OK. They're looking a little frail, you know." Is this him leaving again or him being kind? Either way, it's having the same affect on me.

I look at all three of them, knowing they'll be gone soon, and standing on the edge of a great divide. Then I say, not bearing the separation and temptation to feel rejection, "What if I want to come too?" My heart channels restrict, thinking their way is my own. I want them to want to be with me.

"Oh, honey, of course you can come too," Estelle says. "It's just that we think you might not be done with your own journey yet."

I know she's right. I know I have to go alone. But I'm starting to feel stripped down to the bones. Like everything I thought, isn't, and everything I wanted, always was. Like my mind is getting quiet and giving me the chance to think new things.

"Here," Edgar says and holds out a crumpled hundred dollar bill. "This should help you out a little bit. It came all the way from Atlantic City hidden in my sock. I have a few more hiding places but they're to get us home."

"We want you to have this though," Estelle adds.

"Thanks," I say and take it almost sorrowfully. Then Dad motions for me to step to the side with him.

"Astoria, I know I haven't been a very good example of a father. But I hope to learn to be what you need me to be and to guide you when you ask for guidance. But for now I want you to have this, to remind you when I'm not there, of what this all is for."

The whole time he's been fumbling with the inside of his flannel pocket, like there's been something pinned there from the inside this whole time. He takes it out and I have no idea what it is. I think it might have been gold at some point, but is now somewhat tarnished. It's a rectangle. It sounds familiar. And then it strikes me where I've heard of it before.

"Is that a gold bar?" my eyes widen and I look over and catch Estelle's eye. "You're giving it to me? Wow."

I touch the edges of the pin and I know its weight in what it stands for. I can't believe he's giving it to me. Even though I don't know yet what it stands for to me. I can't believe there are things worth fighting for, and I can't believe my father wants me to, delights I do.

I pin it to my sweatshirt. I don't want to forget. This whole time I've been looking for something, unsure of whether it's real and worth looking for, and this gives me hope that it is.

They turn to head down the street, flag down a cab, and wave as they drive off at the proverbial sunset. then here I am. Alone. With only one way to go.

Chapter 7

I find a diner off the beaten path and get some food. There is a show girl there, all feathers and hot pink and high heels. She smells like lilacs and powder, her makeup is flawless like a queen, but a fierce queen of the Amazons. I watch her tanned skin and jangling bracelets and ornaments. Her eyelids are heavy with liquid turquoise but her eyes are wide open. Her costume moves with her.

I push my eggs and black beans around on my plate. I'm not even hungry. I'm all filled up inside with silence. The Amazon is being loud, flirting heavily with someone hidden by her headdress. I think that I will maybe hitchhike or buy a plane ticket to L.A. I could walk or find a train or maybe meet someone who's going there, maybe steal a car or rent one and pretend I'm older than I am. I wouldn't really do all those things, I'm just hoping one might spark a brilliant idea. Lost in plotting I hardly notice when the woman leaves and that the man she was talking to is a cop. I think of the one episode I ever saw of Reno 911 and picture him wearing spandex. So I feel uncomfortable when he walks over to me holding a photograph of my mirror image.

"Astoria Teller?" he says holding the photo up to my face. I nod. "Come with me."

He puts me in his flashing lights car and we drive away from the madness. To say that I'm calm is an understatement. I suppose he could be picking me up for a number of things. Right now, after the pirate discombobulation, nothing would surprise me. I'd survive and move on. I'm kind of glad for the adventure. I'm alone again for the first time and everything settles around me, it sinks in where I've been and what I've done. What would Xan say if he knew? I never did get back to him after missing that check point.

The cop talks to me through the divider. I want to give him a doughnut. He says, "So you know what I picked you up for?"

"No," I say, thinking it could be for bribing a transportation official, leaving an abandoned bus in the middle of the desert, or cohorting with wilderness warlords.

Instead, he says, "You've got one very worried mother who must love you very much."

"Oh. That," I say.

"When we found that bus in the desert we thought we were onto something, and some frazzled people have been calling in reports of highway robbers. So it led me right to you I guess. What are you doing out here anyway? Running away from something?"

I think for a moment. "Yeah." Then I add, "I'm trying to get to Los Angeles, can you take me there?"

"No, sorry m'am. Your mother is waiting for us."

"She's here!" I say exasperated, my gaze finally pulled away from looking out the window into the Nevada night and over to the cop. I think this is the worst thing that could happen. For sure she will make me come home. I can't see her.

We get closer and closer to our final destination, the county jail and sheriff's office. I clam up, maybe it is time to just go home. We walk into the cold air conditioned building that smells like the sticky part of envelopes and smells like burnt coffee. People are filing papers and fans are blowing them apart, making their job harder than it should be. The cop leads me to get finger printed and makes me wait for him on a hard bench.

I feel like a failure.

I think I will feel embarrassed when Xan asks me if it was worth it, asks me what I found. I don't want to answer in the negative. I don't want to say, 'You were right. This is it. Life is just hard and we endure it.' Because if that is true, why endure it? Why would we put ourselves through it? There is nothing special about me or my place on the earth.

Then the cop comes back for me and leads me to a private room with a table and two chairs where I'm to wait for my mom. Here is the solitude I wanted, here is the time to think and sort out, here is where I see what I'm left with. The room is dark and cool and quiet, almost uncomfortably so. My mind buzzes and rattles like the links of a chain being pulled against each other, holding my thoughts down and in place or strapped to an electric chair. All I want is out of them.

I hear some noise in the hallway. It sounds like my mother's high heels and I hear her arguing to see me. But she's being held up by paperwork and waiting in the main office. I also hear another voice with her. It's deeper and slower and sounds rougher like a boy. Xan! My desire to see him draws a sword on my desire to escape from my mom. They both burn in my chest. They're going to take me home. If it was my choice that would be fine, but being forced to leave before the journey is finished is like a painting half painted or another broken dream, degrading and shameful.

I hear the door click and I brace myself to put up a fight or to at least go down resisting. The door starts to open and a hand reaches in first, as the person seems to look both ways before deciding it's safe to enter. Then he walks into the light and it's my dad! He puts a finger up to his mouth telling me to be quiet. I dare have hope again.

I whisper, "How did you find me? I thought you were leaving with Edgar and Estelle?"

"I was, but we decided someone should hang around and follow you, make sure you don't get into any trouble. So when I saw the cop pick you up I hitched a ride behind you. I used some money Edgar gave me from his underwear."

"You were there this whole time?" I say more relieved and honored than angry.

"Story, I've always been here, if only you asked for me." He looks at me tenderly. "Now, do you want to get out of here or do you want to go home? I was going to let you figure things out but when I saw your mom arrive I thought you could use some help."

To actually feel the love of my father breaks my heart like an eggshell trying to hold itself together until the first peck of the new baby bird.

"I want to keep going," I say. "But I'm scared. What if there's really nothing there? Even if I get to L.A. maybe nothing will be different inside of me."

"Even if it's not, and all this turns out to have been a waste of time, at least you will have accomplished what you set out to do."

"But I don't think I could take it," I say. "If there is no change there isn't anything."

My father looks at me directly. "There is you. Isn't that enough?"

"Who am I?" I say searching his face for answers.

He softens and knows how to win my heart. "You are my daughter. And you are loved. And you were made the way the sun, the moon, and the stars were made. The way the oceans

learned which direction to flow and the way the tree knows how to grow toward the sun. You were made with as much purpose to be beautiful and you were made to have life, abundantly. It's not wrong for you to want those things. It's your birthright. Look, don't be afraid. You will find it."

He reaches into his back pocket and pulls out a hand drawn map on the back of a paper napkin from that diner. "This jail system was one of my assignments a few years ago. I designed all the ins and outs of it. I know how you can get out without anyone noticing. Just follow my directions. After a while I'll head off your mom. I don't know how much time it will buy but you should be able to at least catch a train by then. There's a station close by, you'll hear it."

We are startled by the sound of doors opening and closing down the hall, my mother's voice protests something, and the sound of her heels clicking as she paces fills the entire building with time passing slowly. I take my dad's map and he shuffles out the door. I open the other door at the opposite side of the room and continue the adventure once again.

Chapter 8

I sneak around and through hallways and desks, hidden and unseen by anyone on duty. The night is almost turning into morning and I can't believe how much time has actually passed. As I exit the building I notice how brilliant the stars are shining above me, calling me towards them, and I run in the direction of steam and chugging and horns and find the train station nearby. Rushing through the wild with the approaching morning air stinging my lungs, I feel stronger in my bones, my muscles contract and carry me on.

I rush through the ornate lobby, the brass, the metal, the copper, the smell of time, and purchase a ticket on the first train leaving for L.A., right now. I have to make this train. There are escalators and stairs, and people with trains of luggage and baby strollers. There are lines and back-ups and nobody is moving. There are people taking their time, as if there is nothing worth moving very fast for. But I have to make this train.

I slip through the heavy doors just in time to feel the train lurch forward, but my footing is steady and I find an empty seat by the window. I wonder what Los Angeles will look like with the sunrise. I wonder what my mom is thinking and how mad she'll be. I think about what my father said. I think about all the places and people I met traveling across the country, not even sure how much time has passed or what day it even is.

We pull into the station. The tension rises between what I hope for and what might not be.

Already the air feels different here like I can breathe without holding it all in. My heart races and I navigate the streets. My eyes search, my feet are aware of every bump in the concrete. I stand now at the Hollywood Walk of Fame. The dream destination of my childhood. The sun rises, it casts yellows and blues into my eyes. My heart shoots life inside of me. The stars below and the stars above safely tucked away into the day. As my dad reminded me, I am made just the same, and by the same. It sinks in. It lifts a burden. It rewires my brain. Maybe strength is believing what's true, instead of what you always have. It's distinguishing lies from truth even when it's hard. Even when it's about you.

The city isn't quite awake yet. No movies have begun their cycles for the day. There is no commotion. No one selling maps to celebrity homes and no one trying to parallel park. Only me and my shoes off with my feet wearing shoes in the cement. I find my favorite story tellers and know I have that in me too. I have worlds left to explore. I have shipwrecks to rummage through,

mummies to unwrap, caterpillars to cocoon, and queens to become. I have life for the living. A future. A destiny.

I have no idea how long I'm there but it feels like an eternity, this knowing that I am OK. My eyes close, I feel the sun on my face. I think this feeling will always remind me that what you seek will be found. That what you want most to be, you are.

Then I hear the familiar sound of clacking heels and my best friend calling my name and my father trailing behind. My mom lets Xan get to me first.

"You nut!" he says and squeezes me tight like my shoulders might snap off. For a moment his embrace is the only thing I'm aware of, like the way you hold something when setting the pieces back together with superglue. "Sorry, I had to tell her," he says. "I hadn't heard from you in too long. I had no idea where you were. And you really missed some cool stuff in science class. But don't worry, I'll tell you all about it."

I want to ask how they knew where to find me but then my mom rushes in and hugs me. "How dare you leave like that," she says, "without asking if I wanted to come along too." She smiles. I can only imagine my mom leaving behind all her responsibilities and hitting the open road without a destination or direction other than leaving. For a moment I see my mom as an adventurer.

It's the first time I've seen my mom and dad together since he left and I wonder what will happen now. Everyone seems so happy. We get food at a nearby vegan restaurant. Xan makes fun of everything we eat. My dad tells stories about being in the war and how he remembers proposing to my mom. My mom laughs and laughs like she hasn't in years. I hold his gold bar close to my chest.

At the airport, while we're waiting for our flight, Dad taps me on the shoulder and tells me to watch the nearest television screen. There's a news story playing and I see our bus driver Ernie being handcuffed and my calculus book being tossed aside with the rest of our company's baggage, which we learn will be sent back to those of us with luggage tags. Phew. The story chronicles no less than fifteen looting occurrences and apparently these guys that Ernie teamed up with have been wanted for over three years. Hopefully nothing that bad will happen to me when I tell Grandma about taking her money. I plan on paying her back though, every cent of it.

I hold the gold bar that Dad gave me and say to him, "You know I really appreciate this. It makes me think I can get through everything now, knowing it's part of something more, of getting somewhere I want to go or become. It's my reminder."

"Good," he says. "I thought you could use it."

Our flight back to the east coast is long. No one has asked about my story yet. No one has asked about what happened. They don't know about the malfunctioning pay phone or the porcupine in the desert or how I fainted and woke up to pirates. They don't know about how much I missed them.

I wonder if I should tell them. If I should offer it up like a gift. But it's not for them, I think to myself. Would they be able to understand without having been there? Would they need to go looking for themselves? If they ask I'll let them know, but for now it's my treasure that I did a lot of digging for.

I look out the window and we're flying in the clouds, retracing my steps back home. But this time there is quiet inside of me and I can still breathe like I did when I got to L.A. I know the

stars still hang in the sky. I think of dreams and how fragile they seem. I want robust ones with strength in their wings, that know they'll definitely come true, that aren't afraid to come into the world and say who they are even when all the odds say they aren't. To believe what's true about them even in the face of doubt. I want dreams made by the creator of the stars.

I breathe in deeply and feel my heart hatching out of its shell. Like the part of me that tried so hard to hold it all together stopped trying to hoard all the pieces. I wonder if the baby bird or the caterpillar ever questions what it will become when it is forming in the dark. If it ever wants to stop the process and go back to what it was. But then I'm sure, just like for me, there's a point at which you would never even desire that because the only thing you can do and still remain alive, is go on.

Chapter 9

When we get home mom lets me stay in bed for a few days before going back to school. All in all it's only been about a week away. I can catch up easy, and in no time Xan and I will be working out equations over pizza and practicing for Spanish exams. It will be like just before I left but everything will be different.

Dad went back to Indiana to get his things and the plan is for him to move back in. I'm sure we'll all have a bunch of things to work out but for now we're enjoying the transition and looking for a bigger apartment.

I'm in the kitchen and it's warm and quiet. The sun shines kindly on the wooden breakfast table where I see a photo of twilight skyline, of hotel rooms lit up safely from within, of neon purple signs and electric clouds. I look closer and see that it says Atlantic City. Why do we have a postcard of our hometown? I smile thinking of Edgar and Estelle and turn over the photo with curiosity. It's addressed to my mom.

"To the mother of Astoria. You must be deeply concerned about the whereabouts of your daughter. I'm writing to let you know she is alright and on the way to Los Angeles through Las Vegas. I met her while traveling and see her address on her luggage tag. As a mother myself I would hate if I didn't know. But go easy on her, she's learning what it means to look for life."

Sneaky Estelle, she must have sent it from one of our rest stops along the way. No wonder Mom knew where to go look for me. I wonder if I will ever see Edgar and Estelle again, if they got home safely, and what celebration will bring them to Atlantic City again.

I'm lost in thought when Xan picks me up to go to our favorite spot. I get in the car and we listen to old mix tapes we made on snow days and remember why we chose each song. When "The Sound of Settling" by Death Cab for Cutie comes on I hope he understands what made me have to leave.

We climb into our favorite booth and order our favorite pizza. The ceiling fans click and give the air a voice. I wonder how things will be between us now that I've returned. What if we don't understand each other anymore or he thinks I've changed too much? Have we experienced too many different things to just come back together like nothing's happened? And why hasn't he asked me about my trip?

"I got your calculus book," I say.

"Oh yeah, what did you think?" he asks as if he forgot he gave it to me. I didn't think Xan forgot those kinds of things.

“It was awesome. I especially like all the notes you wrote in the corners and how you worked out your own equations on the side.” I want him to press in, I want him to ask. Math can’t be the only thing he wants to talk about.

I remember before I left he asked if I would be OK. And he said I would be strong enough and smart enough to make it all the way, whatever the way was. I remember thinking he wouldn’t come after me. But he did.

I want to tell my best friend about my heart and about holding all my pieces when I needed two hands free to climb and see the view from the top. I want to tell him I could hold onto his.

Instead we sit there and I wait for the pizza to cool off enough so that it won’t burn the roof of my mouth. I look at him and feel so much gratitude that he’s been my friend. I think of my mom who told me she wants to go on her own journey now, and my dad who seems to understand me even more than myself.

Xan stops eating for a moment and I think he’s going to tell me more about quadratic equations and what to do with imaginary numbers, and I want to know because it lets me get close and feel let in. Instead, he smiles and says, “Finally. You need to tell me your story. Will you share with me what you found?”

My heart jumps to the smile in my eyes and I start from the beginning, “I thought you’d never as.”

Maybe Free

Chapter 1

My mom and I are not best friends, but today I called her and asked for advice. She said, “Allegra, you have to get your ducks in a row. You do just the opposite. When you see ducks, you say ‘Whee ducks!’ and chase them all around.” Thanks Mom.

I’m lying on the rug on the laminate floor in the bathroom of the place where I work. Let’s call it *Building of Death* and this is my *Lair* where I go to fume so I don’t set the *Building of Death* on fire or throw eggs all over the walls. It reminds me of the Grinch’s cave in *How the Grinch Stole Christmas*. I am the Grinch.

Sometimes I lie here and dig my fingernails as far into the shag as they’ll go. Right now, I grip the floor for dear life so I don’t fling myself across the room, and I open my mouth to make what would be the most perfect, hair-splitting, deafening scream, from the most Grinchiest place inside of me; but my vocal cords never touch. I am the only one to hear it. I imagine how lovely and relieving and passionate it would feel to scream. Instead it stays locked inside of me and slips down into my soul added to the trash heap of voiceless resistance growing inside of me.

Sometimes I just stare into my eyes in the mirror and whisper only loud enough for myself to hear that *I can get through this, I can do this, I believe in myself, and everything will be OK.*

Sometimes I believe it.

I am locked in the bathroom, but down the hall is cake and balloons and seven happy, chubby coworkers celebrating my five year anniversary working at the *Building of Death*. I call it the *Building of Death* because when I am here it is always killing me. I sit inactive for eight plus hours, reach for sweets and snacks, reward myself with sugary, creamy coffee. Death rises off my chair like a puff of dust when I sit. It is like planting a tree in toxic soil. My roots absorb and feed me death, so naturally I will die. Inside.

I do want the cake though. I love cake, especially at the *Building of Death*. It is moist and sunshine yellow with a delicate lavender buttercream frosting that writes you love notes and then stabs you in the back, or love handles. The *Building of Death* gives me an unhealthy relationship with food.

Sometimes I close my eyes and pretend I am on stage in a performance with *Cirque du Soleil*. I pretend that this office is just a set lowered down from the big top, and then whisked away at the end of the scene, that my suffering is that of a clown whom the audience loves and identifies with and wants to see succeed.

There is a tap on the door and I know it is Kaycee because she always scratches first and knocks with the palm of her hand. I let her in today.

Sometimes I don’t.

“Are you going to come back to the party? *Dragon Lady* is wondering where you are.”

Dragon Lady is like a minotaur, despite being called a dragon, wandering in her labyrinth, the way she roams around the *Building of Death*. We call her *Dragon Lady* because fire unexpectedly escapes from her lips and we wonder if she is starting to spontaneously combust inside. I watched a documentary about that once. People go up in flames from the inside and sometimes the only thing that’s left is a shoe. Even their surroundings crisp up like they’ve been assaulted with a blow torch for a hot minute.

Sometimes I’m afraid that will happen to me. Seeing as it’s spontaneous I wouldn’t be

able to plan it, and I like to have things planned. When there is no plan I feel like there is no value put on time, and when you don't value time everything hangs in limbo.

"Yeah, I'm coming," I say to Kaycee. "Are you still in this with me?" I refer to our plan *Operation Escape*. She wants to go to cosmetology school and design hair. I think it's wonderful. Tinfoil highlights, hairspray, beauty. I want to write novels, teach yoga, and open a small business showing women what to do with kale and other unknown vegetables and healthy food.

"Of course," she says. "My husband just started a new job and it's looking like we might have enough with his income for me to leave within a few months. We're going to find out later this week, he has a few meetings set up with his employers."

Maybe it is coming together. Now I need some light at the end of my tunnel. I splash some water on my face to cool it down and breathe deeply. I wash my hands. It smells like ammonia and embalming fluid. One last time I look in my own eyes and grunt with dedication in my own personal football huddle, breaking to get back in the game.

Sometimes I forget a helmet and it's really easy for the other side to get in my head with their riddles and confusion. I hate being easily deceived. I have to remember my helmet.

At the party, Kaycee throws streamers and confetti at me. She blows one of those plastic kazoo horns which should be made illegal. Janice sits across from us eating half the cake, some crumbs sticking to her top. Half the cake is literally on her plate. Kaycee puts a party hat on my head and the elastic band cuts into my chin and behind my ears. Death by throat slit. Not unexpected.

Janice says through her mouthful, "How's the boyfriend? Is he coming to visit anytime soon? Is the long distance getting harder or easier?"

"He's fine, Janice," I say as I snap the elastic up under my chin again. Janice is everything I do not want to become. She's been at the *Building of Death* for twenty four years and somewhere along the way she morphed into the *Living Dead*. She's probably a vampire. When she asks me questions about my life, I can feel her draining the blood right out of me. Life is precious in a place like this.

Then *Dragon Lady* pops her smoldering head in and asks to see me in her office. Even walking to her office feels like a race, she can't do anything without making it a competition. The only personal items in her office are trophies and goal tracking calendars. At least a lot can be accomplished with persistence and commitment. I'll give her that much.

Now, the *Building of Death* has been her baby for over thirty years and it's actually a wealth management firm. We help people decide what to do with their money and then they give us some of it. My only real interest in the job is that dollar signs are pretty. I like the soft delicate beautiful shape of the 'S' and the strong dominant directness of the lines. It's like my relationship with *Boyfriend*. I get to be beautiful and he gets to be strong and when we come together we symbolize something much more than an 'S' and a line on their own.

My boss asks me to have a seat and then jumps right in. "Allegra, I am so happy with your performance. You single handedly pay half the salaries in the office with your work alone. I can't get over how fast and efficiently you work and I really want to show you my appreciation." This is very flowery conversation coming from the one who eats knights in shining armor. "So I want to give you a promotion. It does mean more hours in the office and greater responsibility, but I trust you enough to do the job and think the extra bonus may make it worth it to you."

No amount of money could make *Death* OK. "So I want you to think it over. We can talk tomorrow and you can let me know. Now go enjoy your party. In another fifteen years you have

a gold watch to look forward to.”

I walk back down the hall and straight to my Grinch’s lair.

Later that night, Kaycee and I meet downtown on Brady Street. We go to this kitschy tea room and order a pot of tea to share. It comes in a glass kettle with a whole flower inside gently coaxed open by the hot water.

Sometimes I would like to feel more like that. Now, I usually feel like someone is just plucking my petals apart.

Around us the room is bright and vibrant and buzzing. Canisters of rare and exotic tea blends line the shelves. We’re trying to work our way around the world in tea. So far I still like a simple Earl Grey the best. There are tea light candles on every table (do they know how funny that is?) and star shaped Christmas lights in the storefront windows. We go upstairs to the small balcony where it is quieter and more private.

I’m wearing a red and orange flowered sundress with the perfect red wedge heels and matching lipstick. Kaycee is wearing her casual Friday work jeans and a graphic tee with a rhinestone skull. I never dress like this at the *Building of Death*.

“At work you’re practically gothic,” Kaycee says.” You wear the same clothes every day like a uniform. But outside you’re such an Aphrodite.”

“I know. It’s my double life. Call me Bond, Allegra Bond.”

“Why do you do it? How do you know which one is really you?”

“That’s easy. The one that is beautiful and fun and free spirited. The other one is just me being crushed under a giant stone press like they used to kill witches during the witch hunts. But I don’t think I have much longer before it totally annihilates the real me. Hey, how much longer do you think before you can quit? And what are you doing this weekend? Tilly and the Wall are playing at the Pabst on Friday and we totally have to go.” We’ve been waiting a whole year for them to come back to town and I can’t wait to hear the tap dancing and percussion that drives their anthems forward.

Sometimes on our lunch break Kaycee and I just drive down the freeway and back for half an hour blasting the *Bottoms of Barrels* album with the windows open. I pretend we’re driving down the Pacific Coast Highway and that I can smell the salt in the ocean air. For a moment everything is hopeful again.

“Actually, my husband has a work party that night. It’s really important to him that I be there. You know, with all this partner business going on. Things look really good and I could get out of here within a month, I’m hoping, if everything comes through for him.”

“What? You’re not going to come with me?”

“Sorry, Allegra.”

“Well, why don’t we go get Indian food at least and watch a movie at my apartment? He can’t have you tied up all weekend.”

“That works, but don’t you have date night with Boyfriend Saturday? We’ll have to make it Sunday.”

“OK, great, it’s a plan.”

We sit sipping our hot tea from pretty flower cups and watch customers down below. I tell Kaycee about what happened in *Dragon Lady’s* office and about the promotion.

“Are you going to take it? You have to take it.”

“Of course I’m not going to take it. I hate working there. I am so not made for this job.”

“But that’s a really great offer. Are you just going to keep working with everything staying the same then?”

“I don’t know.”

“Do you think it’s time to go?”

“I don’t know.”

“Do you have another job lined up?”

“Stop asking me questions, OK. No, I don’t have another job lined up, I don’t know what to do. I’m not sure how to get my feet off the ground. I can’t make any decisions until I know I’m free from this first.” I pause. “Sorry, this is a touchy subject.”

“When do you have to tell her your decision?”

“Tomorrow. She wants to start training me Monday for the new position.”

“Yikes. Talk about pressure.”

“Yeah. Hey, let’s get out of here. I could use a walk down the street and maybe some shopping. There’s nothing like some new sparkle eyeshadow to brighten the night.”

We step outside and the warm, almost-summer, Milwaukee air puts an arm around my shoulder and I pretend that it’s *Boyfriend*. I am sure tired of pretending all the time. Then Kaycee links arms with me and we pass the hot dog shop and some high class bars and the hookah lounge. At night I feel free and wild like I could howl at the moon, like I never want the day to come, as with the escaping moonlight I turn back to a girl with a job hidden away from the world.

Kaycee lets me try her new toasted almond flavored lip gloss and it brings me back to middle school and saving up my change for ice cream day in the cafeteria. It was always a toss up between the toasted almond bar or the orange Flintstone’s push up pop.

We walk down to the lakefront, take off our shoes, put our feet in the sand, and try to hunt for shells and sea glass in the dark. I don’t realize how close I am to the water until I feel my feet in it and the coolness shocks me. But I stay and play and try to splash Kaycee with my toes. Soon we’re laughing and smiling and having a good time and I remember what it’s like to not be depressed. In a way it falls off like dead skin cells sloughed off my heel with a pedicure, though I know it will build back up tomorrow.

Once our calves tire of running through the dark water we lay on the sand and look up at the stars. I don’t even care that it is in my hair or in my dress. I just want the best seat in the house.

“Hey,” Kaycee says. “Look over there.” She points to a group of stars that no one ever really notices, but that I’ve been looking at my whole life. “That looks just like the freckles on your neck. How cool.”

“Ha, when I was younger my dad told me I had the *mark of the creator* on me, like the signature of Picasso at the bottom of his painting.”

I remember those summer nights with my family camping out in our own backyard so that we could run extension cords to a little TV and mini fridge. My parents always made sure we looked up at the sky though and spent some time in awe. Now that I’m older it’s more important to me than ever to not forget. I would tattoo it on my forehead to always remember.

When it gets a little later, Kaycee and I say goodbye and I walk back to my apartment on Farwell. I scratch Strawberry Shortcake’s head and sit with her on my shoulder as I work on

some new jewelry designs and novel ideas. Strawberry Shortcake is my white-fronted amazon parrot with a swirl of white and red feathers above her beak. She moved across the country with me when I came to school here in the Midwest. We've stayed ever since, but we talk about how much we miss home on the East Coast sometimes too. Strawberry Shortcake only says "Hello" and "I love you," so I do most of the talking. I'm trying to teach her to say "Hold on" but it's just coming out as "Old one" and that doesn't help very much.

I kneel on the floor by my bed like my parents taught me when I was young and I get really still and quiet inside. This takes quite a few minutes. Then I say, "God, I need wisdom about what to do tomorrow. I'm scared." And I wait, and I wait, and then I go to sleep in peace.

Chapter 2

On Monday morning, I start to put flowers in my hair and grab the new purple glitter eyeshadow to put on, but then decide not to. I put on my college sweatshirt instead. I eat some leftover quinoa and roasted root vegetables for breakfast. I text *Boyfriend* good morning. I kiss Strawberry Shortcake goodbye and she says, "I love you." Then I drive myself to the *Building of Death*. I wish I could spend my days doing things that bring me Life.

The drawbridge goes up and I am once again the princess in my lonely tower. *Dragon Lady* brings someone new around and introduces him to all of us. His name is Page and he's the new intern. I look at him skeptically and maliciously, but when I see how excited he is to work here, how there is nothing else in life he would rather be doing because wealth management for-some-strange-reason fulfills him, how he's wanted this since eighth grade, how happy he is here, I think I should be feeling that way about what I do all day long too. Then I look at him with jealousy. Then inspiration.

I watch him sneakily out of the corner of my eye. How can someone be that excited about this job? Then I remember how I used to feel that way about starting my own business, about being creative and bringing a spark of life into other people's lives. I remember my business plans and projections and how fearful I am of believing in myself enough.

I look at the picture of *Boyfriend* and I on my desk. It was taken almost a year ago when we went on a mission trip with a non-profit organization to provide flood relief and help people with nothing left. I also have these pinned up images of brightly colored objects like umbrellas and crayons and strange animals. I have a coffee mug my grandma gave me that I keep my pens in, and a calendar of natural wonders like the Grand Canyon and Niagara Falls. Everything about my desk says I'd rather be somewhere else. So when my boss calls me into her office I know exactly what to say.

"Allegra, I hope you've had time to think about my offer. I'd love to make you my new Office Manager."

"I really appreciate the offer, but this job really isn't for me. Someone else would be much happier with the position and I would be much happier somewhere else."

"Are you saying you want to leave the company?"

"Yes. I'd like this to be my two week notice." Silence. I think I feel my adrenaline bolt out the starting gate like the horse races I've seen on TV.

"Is everything OK?" she asks.

“Yes. I’ve just seen what works for me and what doesn’t, and what I need in a work environment.”

“Well, as a mother, the mother in me just has to say that I think you are making the wrong decision and you are young and don’t know what to value. In a few years or just a little while I think you’ll realize what you walked away from and how you had it made.”

I see a puff of smoke escape her lips. I think this is inappropriate. Though, she is losing a major organ in her system. I should be sensitive to that. I continue to tell her how thankful I am to have had the opportunity and come off sounding more sure than I am and feel more hurt than I should.

She excuses me from her office and a smile creeps across my lips. Finishing out the day is tough because I keep daydreaming about potential future scenarios and I don’t want anyone to see me actually smiling on the job, they might get the wrong idea.

Even though I still have two weeks, I go through my desk and put all my personal trinkets in a box from the mailroom. I find some notes stashed at the back of one of my desk drawers and read them. Then I remember why I saved them. They are between Kaycee and me from when we came up with *Operation Escape*. I had originally wanted to call it *Operation Dragon Slayer* but then realized she wasn’t the real enemy. I put the notes in the box and decide I’ll frame them one day when I’m really happy with my new job.

Chapter 3

On the weekend I go to Frame Park in Waukesha to see the water skiers practice. Sitting in the mini outdoor amphitheater I see couples with dogs and kids, a man with an ice cream cart, and a baseball game about to begin. I brought some designs with me that I’m working on for every day prom dresses. I think they could be a big hit. Sometimes the ideas just come, like a strange insect on the sidewalk you bend down to inspect, unable to look away because there is something so captivating about such a creature existing. I imagine that’s how Adam might have felt about Eve. Captivated. So when I design or write it’s not so much about making things up, but about the privilege to witness such captivating things that need to be recorded and documented as having had existed.

I suppose I should be on the mad job hunt, but I feel a sense of peace, like everything is already worked out. Maybe it’s the calm before the storm or maybe it’s true. Either way, I’m enjoying it. I just wish Kaycee were in the boat too.

I go home and get ready for my date with *Boyfriend*. It’s on the phone. I still shave my legs and pluck my eyebrows and wear perfume. It’s like a ritual and it gives more value to an everyday act like talking on the phone. So I don’t take it for granted.

We weren’t always apart like this. We met in college here and started to become friends our senior year. He would always go out of his way to walk with me somewhere across campus, or to ask if I needed anything when studying. He made me laugh all the time, and yet could have really serious discussions about theology and the economy. Right before graduation he asked if I wanted to get some custard at Kopp’s. They were making my favorite that day, Cherry Amaretto Cheesecake.

We were sitting outside by the waterfall enjoying our two scoops and he started talking about how much more he wanted to get to know me, and how beautiful I am inside and out, and

how he'd been praying about telling me this for a long time. He said he had feelings for me that were more than just friendship and he asked if I would begin a courtship with him. I had been secretly desiring this for a while but knew I had to wait for him to show interest first, for him to pursue me, and for me to feel worth fighting for.

Soon after that he went to grad school in North Carolina and now he's graduating this year. We have to be very intentional about our time together and make sure we communicate extra clearly. We see each other once in a while, but this wouldn't work if we both didn't know in all certainty that this is it for us.

I'm in the middle of brushing my teeth and haven't even done up my hair yet when the phone rings. Strawberry Shortcake squawks and squawks. She only does that when one specific person is on the phone, like a hyper sensitive drug-sniffing dog. I spit in the sink and jump over the half finished project on my weaving loom. I'm making a quilt for my grandmother. I catch the phone on the last ring and give Strawberry Shortcake a Nutter Butter to keep her quiet. I eat one too.

"Mom," I say answering, "*Boyfriend* is calling me in half an hour and I haven't even started trying on outfits yet." I look at myself in the full length mirror and hold my stomach in, then let it out. "What's up?"

"Your grandfather just had a heart attack and we're at the hospital waiting for them to finish surgery."

"What," I say, not ask. The room suddenly becomes invisible around me. I don't even feel my feet on the floor. My heart shuts its doors. "What happened?"

"He was building that row boat he always wanted in the garage and your uncle came over to surprise him with a sundae from Friendly's. They were eating ice cream and he was getting excited showing off his new boat and the next moment he was on the ground. Your grandma and I followed them and now we're all just waiting for more details."

Sometimes I just feel like I'm waiting for more details on the status of my heart too.

She says that she'll let me know when they have more information, that I should hang tight for now. Strawberry Shortcake tries to say "Hold on."

I realize I haven't even told my parents yet about my big decision. But now isn't the right time. Then I hear a beep on the phone.

"Mom, someone's calling me. Let me know when you know more." I click over and it's *Boyfriend*, early for our date. I had still wanted to play some Norah Jones and meticulously curl my eyelashes while anticipating all the wonderful things we would talk about.

"Hi Sweetheart," he says. "It's so great to hear your voice." My heart flutters and makes little pitter patter sounds. "But listen Girl, my boss just called me and is literally begging me to come in tonight. Almost everyone on the wait staff is home sick and they're sinking fast. He knows how important Date Night is to me but had no other choice."

"No. Really?" I say trying to convey hope.

"Really, Sweetie. I am so sorry, you know how much all I want to do is spend time with you. You mean so much to me. I can't believe this is happening tonight. But we'll talk soon. I promise. You mean the world to me and I'm going to get to you as soon as possible, you better believe it."

We say our goodbyes and I stare dumbfounded, wondering how a night can get so turned around and land on its head, not even butter side up. *Boyfriend* doesn't even know about my job or my grandfather or my uncurled lashes.

I suddenly feel more alone than I bargained for and like I'm the keeper of some world changing secret. Keeping it inside almost makes me feel like it's not real, like I'm making it up, like I'm perfectly fine and capable of handling this on my own. When really, I'm actually not.

It feels like someone rubbed Icy Hot all over my heart, and that someone was me.

Chapter 4

Back in the office during our morning staff meeting, I sit back in my chair and try to hide behind the heads of my coworkers. My eyes are too heavy to shine and I'm too distracted to follow anything that's being said. Everyone else leans forward in their chairs, they engage their pens or notebooks or elbows on the table. My stomach hurts.

I think about some of the potential jobs I've seen posted on bulletin boards around town. I have an interview this afternoon but everyone at work thinks I'm leaving to go to a doctor's appointment. The intern, *Page Boy*, keeps looking at me greedily like he wants to win the jousting competition and be rewarded with my job. His suave demeanor makes me uncomfortable and I feel like I can't trust him. Actually, he just reminds me of *Boyfriend* and it makes me angry that we aren't together.

Around three o'clock I leave and go over to the Pooch Palace. They have an opening for a salon technician. I don't really like dogs but maybe this could work. The woman who interviews me has on a lot of makeup and is wearing layers of pastel shawls and shrugs. She is going on and on about the quality of a dog's life and how the pampering at the Palace transcends everyday life for them. Her office is filled with doggy memorabilia. Bubble heads, posters, figurines, doggie print t-shirts and stockings on display, a mug collection, and even a giant stuffed Dalmatian. I'm not sure if it is real; and her office smells like bacon.

She asks me why I want the job and I say because it does not involve a computer or sitting at a desk for eight hours. I don't think she really likes that answer because her eye twitches and she spends a long time writing something down with her fluffy dog paw print pen. I'm not sure having my roots in *Dog* would be much better than having them in *Death*.

When I get home I grab some homemade garlic hummus and celery sticks from the refrigerator.

"Shortcake, I have your favorite," I call out and get a stick ready for her. I can't wait to tell her all about the Pooch Palace and how maybe we should start a pampering service for birdies. At least she'll laugh with me.

But when I get to her favorite perch she's not there. Nor is she strutting in front of the mirror in the bathroom looking at her pretty feathers. She's not trapped underneath the sofa, she's not in my bedroom under the covers in my bed where she goes sometimes when there are tornado warnings and the big siren goes off all day long. She's not sleeping in her cage or trying to pry open her snack cabinet. She's just gone.

For a while I am convinced that somebody stole her to sell her little bird kidneys on the black market. Do birds have kidneys? I have to remember to look that up. Then I remember the escape hatch. It's a little stained glass window in the bathroom that I always keep open so that I don't feel suffocated in my apartment. I told Strawberry Shortcake when we got here that if she ever needed to break free and stretch her wings and remember what it's like to fly she could use the escape hatch. She's done it once before so I shouldn't be too worried, but I wish she could

leave me a note or something, and I wish I could fit out the escape hatch too.

I sit quiet and alone in my apartment, just staring. The phone is next to me so I can catch it right away if it rings. Each time I look at it I feel like I lost a hundred dollars in a game of Roulette. I cover the phone with a pillow before I go bankrupt. I feel sticky and restless inside, like packing tape or plastic wrap that gets stuck around itself. What if my heart closes up? What if it shuts down? What if I don't believe in anything anymore? What if my eyes are forever tired and dim and I never look forward to waking up in the morning?

"Stop it!" I shout. If someone was around they would consider having me treated for schizophrenia. But I just have to talk to myself sometimes. I have to give myself a vaccination before the plague spreads and right now I'm starting to feel it's creepy crawly fingers meddling in my business. I stand up on the couch and I jump up and down until I'm out of breath sending out disciplines and encouragements to myself.

"Stop! Stop! Stop! Stop!" bounce bounce bounce bounce. "You are not going to lose your heart! You are taking steps to keep it open and you won't become an uncreative spinster whose only joy is making toast each morning!" I slump back down on the couch and laugh a little at what it takes sometimes to come back from the edge.

Then the phone rings. I scramble amidst all the pillows on the couch trying to find which one it's under. Strawberry Shortcake isn't there to tell me who it is.

"Hello?" I say as if expecting someone new and exciting and great and out of the ordinary.

"Hi," my mom says back. "What are you doing?"

"Nothing." I never tell anyone about my coping methods.

"Well, listen, I have more news about your grandfather." Suddenly taking the focus off myself reminds me how easy it is to be self-centered. I have to work on that.

"What? What happened? How did it go?"

"Not that good. Things were looking OK right after the surgery and he was sitting up talking to all of us, but then sometime during the night he passed away. At least it was more peaceful."

"Not that good! That's how you describe it? No, it's not good. It's heartbreaking, it's bad, it's unsuccessful." I really don't want to take my anger out on her, and I really do.

"Well, whatever you want to call it. The funeral is at the end of the week, do you think you can make it?"

"Yeah," I say without thinking.

"Well how do you know, don't you have to check with your boss?"

"No, really, it will be OK."

"Allegra, you need to ask for time off first."

"Mom, it's fine."

"How do you know, you should just ask."

"I quit my job, OK!" It spews off my lips like hot lava from an erupting volcano and it feels so good to have it outside of me. Though I'm not anticipating the mess it will make.

"Do you have something else you're doing?"

"No."

I know she is looking at this and seeing a million rubber ducks strewn around the room, and no one is making way for them.

“How are you going to pay your bills?”

“I have money saved to live on until I find something.”

“Do you know how many people would just kill to even have any job right now and you’re just throwing yours away?”

“Yes, Mom, I know.”

“No to mention you still have student loans to pay and an apartment. As long as you can make ends meet, I guess.” You would think she was the one doing it and realizing all the odds against her.

“Mom, I’ve thought about all this. It’s something I have to do.”

“Then why don’t you just come home if you’re starting all over again. You know if this were five years ago and you were just trying to find yourself it would be different. But you’re an adult, people don’t do things like this. It’s like you’re going backward. Next thing you’ll say is you’re taking a lower paying job.”

This is not an easy thing to do.

We hang up and I think about what she said and about moving home. Maybe that could work. I could probably go back to the cafe I worked at in high school. I could live at home for a little while. I could figure things out. It would be hard living with my parents. I would probably feel like a failure for a little while. I hope it’s only a little while. But, don’t I owe it to myself to try something completely different if what I’m doing isn’t working? What if it’s just what I need? What if my mom is right?

Chapter 5

At the *Building of Death* I tell *Dragon Lady* what’s going on and my need to leave earlier than planned. There’s no point in coming back after the funeral.

She gets a panicked expression in the lines of her face and the next thing I know *Page Boy* is moving into my office. She hires him on the spot and tells me I should just go home. I can tell he is trying not to smirk or snarl or something with his lips.

Janice catches me at the water cooler. “So, what are you going to do? A smart girl like you must have a plan right?” I can tell she hopes that I don’t.

“Right,” I answer.

“So, what is it? Are you moving to North Carolina to be with *Boyfriend*? Or are you working at the Pooch Palace?” She raises an eyebrow, privy to insider information. “Mindy is my sister and she said she wouldn’t hire you in a million years, you don’t have an ounce of dog love in you. Really, Allegra, what were you thinking?”

“I’m moving home to the East Coast, Janice, I’ll find something there.”

“Well, if that isn’t the stupidest thing I’ve heard in a long time. Going back to mommy and daddy when you have a perfectly fine job here.”

“A perfectly fine job isn’t everything.”

Kaycee comes over.

“I heard.” She blocks Janice from my view and stands between us. “I’ll miss you.” She hugs me and I see Janice’s repulsed face and eye roll as she finishes getting some water and slumps away.

“When are *you* leaving?” I say to her, wanting her to be free too. She kind of looks down and away and embarrassed like she’s letting me down, or maybe herself.

“I’m not.” Oh. She is going to break my heart. “It just doesn’t work for us right now. I’ll probably be here another year at least.” She pauses, she bites her lip. “But hey, I’m happy for you!”

“Want to walk out to my car with me?” I ask.

In the parking lot we stand looking at the *Building of Death*. I don’t think I’ll really feel free until I get on the road, but for now it’s like looking over the ruins of a burned down city.

“What are you going to do now?” Kaycee asks.

“I need to get my car serviced and fix a few things before driving across the country. Then I’ll pack up and hit the road. Strawberry Shortcake is missing again though. If you see her will you hold onto her for me?”

“Of course.”

“We hug again and wipe away little tears from each other. She walks back inside and I watch the building swallow her whole.

I’m able to get my car in right away and they shuttle me to my apartment while I wait. I don’t have much so it’s easy to pack up exactly the same as when I moved here. I have the hula man lamp, oil paints, art supplies, my Tinker Bell makeup bag, and toiletries. The apartment came furnished so that’s easy and my lease has been month to month since three years ago so all I need to do is make a phone call. I give my food to the neighbor with crazy red hair and oversized clothing down the hall and do a quick scrub down. Being clean and neat really pays off at times like this, there’s not much to do.

The car service shop calls to discuss what they found wrong with my ten year old beetle. Apparently the radiator is damaged from the bottom, like I drove over something angry, and the timing belt needs to be replaced, and the brakes are about to give way. Basically, my car might explode any moment. That’s what I take away from the conversation. Repairing it will cost thousands, multiple thousands. Now, not only am I losing my last week and a half of pay by leaving before my two weeks are up, I’m also draining the money I had saved to live on until finding more work.

I approve the repairs and when I hang up every fear inside of me comes out my eyes, like water rushing in to fill the Titanic, but in reverse.

For a moment I think I should stop the whole process and see if I can get my job back. I worry about how I will have enough money to do anything. I think, what if everyone else is right? But then I remember that night in my bedroom on my knees crying out to God. And I remember the certainty and the peace with which this decision came. I can’t let this throw me off what’s right. Everything always works out.

I get my car back late that afternoon and cram my whole life into the yellow bubble. I can’t even wait until tomorrow to leave. On the way out of town I stop at Alterra on the Lake, my favorite local coffee shop, and get an African Chai for the road. It’s late spring so the weather is opening itself up in the nighttime, inviting us to come out, like *A Midsummer’s Night Dream*. I’ve always wanted to drive away at sunset, and it’s every bit as romantic as it seems. I’m feeling a rushy hope and renewal, like unfurling my wings. Free.

Chapter 6

The ride to Rhode Island is swift and fierce. I weave through the mountains on the Pennsylvania Turnpike, passing monstrous tractor trailer trucks, and succumbing to the breathtaking beauty of the gorges surrounding me. There's not really any time for planning on the eighteen hour trip. Instead, my heart sits at the table of its sustainer and eats back to normal, to plump and healthy. Before it was looking mangled and malnourished, eating scraps off the floor. Sometimes it feels so juicy and alive I smile for hundreds of miles at a clip, and sometimes it rests and takes a nap to repair its own deep gorges in its slumber and I am extra quiet and careful not to startle it.

An eagle flies along the route with me for a while. I imagine it is telling me that even youths grow tired and weary, but those who hope in the Lord will soar on wings like eagles. Soaring is like a natural wonder of the universe. It is effortless. It is giving way to the wind, to being carried, to accepting where you are.

The phone rings. It startles me since I've been lost in thought. It's *Boyfriend*. Finally I tell him all about my decision to leave Milwaukee and go home, about my grandfather, and Strawberry Shortcake, about my car repairs and losing my last week of work. He listens and asks me questions and makes me talk about how I'm feeling. Then he changes the topic.

"Hey, how would you like it if I could come up there for a visit after my last exam for the semester?"

"Of course, I love it, that would be great!" Sometimes I think he has no idea how when we talk I feel like I'm in a hot air balloon looking over the ocean at sunrise, seeing dolphins and seagulls waking for the day and laughing and playing and doing everything they're supposed to do because it's in them and how can they not. Inside I feel clouds forming the shape of mermaids, and jelly bean trails in April leading to baskets of chocolate and pastel Pez dispensers. I feel like me.

He tells me about his week and missing me, about his plans for the future and us. He reminds me of all the things we've learned being together and of all the goals we're working toward. He builds me up with encouragement and love, with affirming words and his affectionate tone. When we hang up my little heart pumps strongly.

When I get to Rhode Island, the air holds secrets from old ships lost at sea and sometimes you can catch them like fireflies. One time I heard men steering away from the Sirens, and another time wishes for a friend from a young one. Iron and Wine is playing when I pull into our driveway in time for dinner.

Our house is perfect. It is on the perfect beach. You can see the ocean from every room in the house. The walls and floors and ceilings are made of wood and it makes me feel like we live in a mansion boat. There are fresh herbs planted outside around the house and flowers I've never seen anywhere else. We always leave the windows open and the surf outside brings a constant breeze so we never use an air conditioner. Our house is perfect.

There's a "For Sale" sign in the yard. I leave everything in my car and run inside. My mom turns away from the green beans on the stove top and my dad puts down his grilling tongs on the front porch. I think they mean to welcome me but I shout first, "What is this?" pointing at the sign outside.

"We didn't want to tell you on the phone since it seemed like you were dealing with a lot

already.” Mom resumes cooking.

“Really? How long have you known? What are you planning to do?”

Dad turns over some chicken. “We’ve been planning it for maybe a year now. We want to go somewhere warm when I retire.”

“You’re retiring at the end of this school year! In like fifteen days! Do you already know where you’re going?”

“New Mexico,” Mom says.

“Great.” I run up to my bedroom to fume and think things over. But when I get up there, there’s no bed, there’s no clothes in my closet, there’s no desk, or my pictures or books or favorite letters and cards taped to the walls. Instead it’s been turned into a nursery with yellow and green everywhere. I run back downstairs.

“What’s going on?”

“I guess we didn’t get a chance to tell you this either. Your sister and Doug moved in a few months ago when he lost his job and they wanted to use your room for the baby.”

“How did no one even mention this to me?”

“Don’t get all worked up Allegra. It’s not like we expected you to be coming home either.”

“OK, it’s fine. I just didn’t expect this. I need to go outside for a while.”

“But dinner is almost ready.”

“I’ll eat later,” and I’m already out the door.

I run out to my favorite jetty a little ways down the beach. The sand pulls at my restless feet like hands reaching out from the grave. I wriggle free from their grasping fingers and my toes cling to the tide-rising wetness of the rocks. It takes balance and a steady mind to make it across the jagged facades, but I do, and I sit with my feet buoyed up by the water and consumed by the darkening ripples in the waves.

Out here everything is as it used to be. There is comfort and there is home.

Then I see something flying at me. It doesn’t look like it’s going to stop. In fact, it might be picking up speed. It gets closer and closer and I pull my feet up from the water thinking I should run, I’ve seen the movie *The Birds*, but I’m mesmerized by its twilight green color and silver shimmer in the almost moonlight. As it gets closer it draws its claws up in front of its breast as if coming in for a landing.

“Hold on! Hold on!” Strawberry Shortcake tweets out and fumbles onto my shoulder, catching herself in my hair.

“Shortcake!” I squeal and nuzzle her beak with my nose and scratch her head so all her feathers stand up. “You made it”

She flew the coop, before she even knew I was planning to leave, and met me here. All those miles alone and she made it to me. We sit looking out at the sea before us and I think even though each wave is individual it pulls itself out of the whole and returns as easily as it came. It doesn’t resist the dance. Maybe it even waits for its time to rise and fall and then gets back in line, like waiting for the water slide when I was younger and then climbing back up the rickety staircase to the top to do it again.

I hear the sound of a train crossing the bridge over an inlet a few houses down from ours. It sounds like orange sunsets and mosquitos that don’t bother you and picnic dinners in your own front yard. It fills me with rumbling that matches the deep rumbling in my soul for life. Sometimes it claws its way out of me with laser Jedi swords from Star Wars and annihilates everything in its path that opposes it. It shatters every barrier in my body. It will not be ignored.

I realize how hungry I've been since the drive and walk back to the perfect house on the perfect beach. The perfect house with the "For Sale" sign.

Chapter 7

The next day is the wake. It's not at a funeral home, or my grandparent's house a little further inland. It's at my grandpa's favorite place to spend a Sunday, the Rhode Island Gun Club.

It's raining, because it always rains for these kinds of things. It makes the grass look greener than it is, like we're in a highly saturated photograph, like more life compensating for death. I think the only reason we're allowed to do this here is because Grandpa has single-handedly supported the club for the last two generations. He doesn't like anyone to know. I wouldn't either, but probably for different reasons.

I'm family so I stay there all day. People bring food to the clubhouse for us but they make things I've never heard of in my lifetime, like cucumber aspic, and liver and onions. I just tell them I'm too upset to eat. I stand next to my grandma all day and watch her eyes roam all around the room and then get real still. I think it is a method to keep from crying. I've seen her do it before. I should try it sometime. She holds onto my fingers or my elbow to steady herself after certain relatives come down the line. She squeezes so tight I think she's developing her own method of Morse Code to tell me family histories.

We're inside but the clubhouse feels damp and muggy and I still sweat a little. It smells like cigar smoke trapped in all the fabric around the room, like my grandpa in a flannel shirt. It's in the couches and chairs, perfuming the air with Man and Yesterday.

People keep coming over to me to tell me stories about my grandfather. They tell me about his first job as the Soda Man, who used to sell soda door to door when it was just practically invented and coke was still in Coke. They tell me how he could shoot a perfect round of skeet but would never enter tournaments, and how when I was born he knocked on everyone's door at three o'clock in the morning to make them come out to see his precious new jewel. It does make me smile. But it also makes me sad.

After a while I go outside to take a break. I sit in the judge's seat under an umbrella on the target field. This is where he took me on my eighteenth birthday and taught me to shoot with every type of gun he owned, which are now all being buried with him. My grandfather never would have let anything hurt us, but I wonder what he would tell me about the *Building of Death* and if I made the right decision. I wonder how he would protect me from that kind of hurt, to my insides. My parents and sister are still inside and I don't think they know about our visits here, our talks walking to the rifle range, and watching men find the satisfaction of shooting at something and not missing.

I decide to call Kaycee and see how things are going for her. I also miss my friend. Now that I'm far away I'm not sure how long we'll stay in touch. She answers even though she's at work and talks to me stealthily in the stock room. We used to watch each others' backs when one of us wanted to make a call like that. I wonder if she has anyone watching hers now.

"Kaycee, hey, how are things?"

"They're actually great, Allegra. Since you left a few things are different now. You remember the intern, Page, right? He works here now. He got us all raises and an hour lunch break instead of a half. He also came up with Employee Appreciation days where we go out together once a month and leave work early for team bonding."

Appreciation. Team. Bonding. Those are words that used to act like poison inside the *Building of Death*.

Kaycee continues, "Even Janice is getting nicer."

I don't say anything. I just watch the rain drip off the umbrella over me. My mouth is open like I might say something, but then Kaycee says someone is coming and she has to go because she doesn't want to be late for the new mandatory staff meeting where they get a chance to talk about what would be more meaningful and helpful to them in the workplace. She hangs up and I pretend to shoot make believe skeet out in the rain.

Back inside I'm wet and cold from being out in the rain. I try to dry off with scratchy brown paper towels from the unisex bathroom that has a chainsaw and paint buckets stored on the floor in the corner. My hair is looking weird and my makeup is gone. I'm pale. My lips are close to purple. I feel like I have ice shingles, like the crystals on a popsicle frozen too long.

I stand by Grandma again and her ginger perfume warms me a little, but it's not long before one of my grandpa's long time friends pulls me aside. He's short and very round. His face is always red and lines are overtaking his face. When I was younger I used to think he must have escaped from a circus, being billed as their Lobster Man. But now I realize you can't have people figured out. He really just works on a shrimp boat and has been in the sun his entire life.

"I hear you're in town for a little while," he wheezes out so I can barely just understand him. "I could use another pair of hands on our boat at least through the summer. Do you have any experience?"

"No, I don't."

"Well, that's OK. Why don't you think about it and let me know tomorrow at the funeral. We can train you up. No problem. Let me know." He pats me on my shoulder, squeezing some water from my dress. He looks at me a little more uncertain than before. I look away. I never thought I would feel so bad about finding my way.

I wrestle all night long thinking about *Lobster Man's* proposition. I do need the money and I do need a job. The hours are long and it's no doubt hard work, especially hard physical labor. It would keep me busy and I'd meet new people. I could survive. I could rely on it.

But I could also feel empty. I might not have time for the things that are truly important to me. It could put me back in the same position I've spent the last three years trying to get out of. It won't define who I am, and this calling in my heart will keep me unsettled there as long as I'm alive to it.

But what if it goes? Working there could snuff out the spark, could make me forget to be alive, could convince me that passion and happiness are foolish to find in a job. It could act like an addiction, making me unable to leave or break the cycle. It could deceive my fragile heart into settling and forgetting.

I want to ask someone for advice, but most people only understand half of the equation. The half that says money and security and getting by. I need someone to encourage me to stay true to what I know is right even in the face of temptation.

I know *Boyfriend* would speak the truth to me. But sometimes I wish there wasn't so much opposition here. I don't even want to mention it to my parents or to Kaycee because of what they would think of me for even considering turning a job offer down.

Chapter 8

In the morning, before the funeral, Grandma comes over for breakfast. She and I sit on the porch overlooking the quiet ocean. Strawberry Shortcake is with us too. I can tell she loves being back home and ruffling her feathers in the salty air. The rest of the family is busy getting ready or cleaning the house or changing diapers, so Grandma and I are alone in silence.

Then she says to me, "I see you still haven't unpacked your car. You drive around looking like a homeless person."

"I feel like one too."

"Well, you're not. You have a home. Just maybe not a physical one yet."

"Sometimes I feel like a magic fairy who took on a human body to come to this world, but it's crushing my magic fairy light and all I can do is turn back into the fairy and go home to where I came from."

My grandma smiles. "Did I tell you what your grandfather left everyone in his will? Well to your sister and her family he left a lot of money, probably enough to put the baby through college and buy her a nice house when she graduates. For your mom and dad, he gave them his condo in New Mexico because he knew it was always their dream."

Wow, these are some pretty hefty gifts. I can't imagine how my life might change when she tells me what I've inherited.

"And for you, he wanted to leave something extra special. Something he said no one else in the family would appreciate as much, and that he felt you would rather have."

Maybe it's his houseboat or his rare coin collection that I could sell!

"He left you all his journals, Allegra. He said that you would understand all that wisdom is far more important than houses or money or possessions. He thought that they would mean more to you than anyone else."

I stare at her blankly, waiting to see if there is more. But there's not. I know I should be overjoyed. I should be thankful and excited. Instead, I feel left out and like an afterthought. Even though I'm sure he intended me to feel the opposite, to feel special and loved, to embrace my difference. But when it comes down to it, I guess money does matter to me too, and having things and being set up to live life. Everyone thinks I'm just some free spirit throwing caution to the wind, when in reality I'm just as nervous as anyone else would be, just as concerned about how everything will work itself out, and trying to survive without dying inside or out. What a tricky process.

I haven't said anything yet to my grandma. So I say thank you and change the subject in hope that she won't address my turmoil within. Instead, I tell her about Grandpa's friend and the job opportunity. I tell her about how I'm thinking of taking it.

"Stop it!" She says. "Stop it right now!" her perfectly coiffed hair shakes a little out of place. "You can not work for the *Lobster Man*!"

"You call him that too?" I start to laugh at my grandma's name for him and how we're always more alike than I think. She chuckles with me and we forget for a moment what a serious day this is.

"Allegra, I know it can be hard to find your way. I've been there too. And one summer a long time ago your grandfather's friend gave me a job on his boat too. I couldn't get out of there fast enough. I felt like every day I gave more and more of my life away. The job wasn't for me. I get the feeling that you know too when something is for you and when it's not. You know about

death and about life. Don't be fooled."

How could I go work for him now? It was as if my grandma saw into my heart and dragged out the truth that was cowering in a corner. I became exposed to someone else, who understands, and who won't let me forget what's right. All of a sudden I am ignited with hope again. I don't have to take this job. I can choose something else. I should not forget that I am desperate for life, but I am not desperate for a job in spite of it.

The decision feels like a quick cauterization, a quick incision, or removal, or sterilization. The pressure to take the job is gone. I am free from feeling like I should, the guilt. I trust in what I know is right, and I have years of my grandfather's wisdom to look forward to.

Chapter 9

At the funeral service I stay close to my grandma. I feel a strange protection of understanding in a certain radius around her and I don't want to step outside the magic shield, especially when everyone asks their favorite question, "So what do you do?" One day that won't make me feel like I need an acceptable answer, but for now I feel strangely unprepared to deal with the decisions I've made. I feel like all of these uncertainties are balancing with me on a tightrope and each step I take either morphs them closer and closer into certainty, or threatens to collapse the whole structure I've created. I don't like being this much in charge sometimes.

When my grandma stands to give the eulogy I am surprised by her ability to do so. Instead of being frail and burnt out she is glowing and hopeful, like the magic fairy clan I feel snatched away from.

She starts by telling a story. It's about them being retired and going to Newport for an afternoon of antique browsing and lobster rolls. She says that people often ask what they do with their time all day long and if life was too boring to bear without being in the workforce. In her story, they strolled out of a perfectly quaint little seaside shop with the whole afternoon before them and they saw a policeman there writing out a ticket. The meter in front of them had only just expired. So Grandpa got a little riled up and started questioning the cop who then decided to write another ticket. At that point Grandma chirped in and between the two of them they churned out a few more adult detention slips. Then they walked away leaving the ticket with the car and to wait for the bus that took them there in the first place. She said at their age it was important to have fun every now and then.

People laughed, though no one was really certain that they should. In fact, I didn't think that was the type of fun they should be having, but knowing my grandparent's mischievous nature I'm sure they just took the opportunity and ran without thinking. Or thinking that it would make for a good story later. I suppose all our trials do.

Grandma continues to talk about her best friend and soulmate, just the same as when I was little and she made it feel like the most passionate thing on earth. She still lights up talking about him. She still believes in love and keeping each other full after all these years. I hope she has another source though because if that's true then she's the next to go on the basis of love starvation. Then again I see a lot of people walking around starved for feeling loved. Maybe it's just another version of the *Living Dead*, outside the *Building of Death*. Maybe a lot of things can make you feel like *Death*.

My grandma finishes and tells us they know the owner of the car and they paid him the money for all the tickets that were their fault. In the end they didn't mind paying the money

because they valued fun enough to pay the price. I think of valuing Life enough and what I would sacrifice for it, like lots of money and security.

After the full military burial we all meet again for the reception at the Gun Club. *Lobster Man* approaches me and asks about my decision, then says he's actually been interviewing other people and really wants to give the job to my brother-in-law anyway. So it all works out. For them.

I see the leftover cucumber aspic from the wake and think about trying it for a moment before all sense comes back to me. There is Chicken Kiev, Steak Diane, and Trout Almondine, recipes from my grandparent's wedding banquet.

Instead of eating I sit away from the commotion and collapse into the oversized sofa surrounding me with the familiar cigar scent of afternoons with Grandpa in the rain. I close my eyes for just a second when I hear, "There's the most captivating girl in the world. Do you think she might bestow on me a hug?" My eyes pop open and I see *Boyfriend* standing right next to me close enough to hear him breathing and I throw my arms around his neck for a long anticipated embrace. Everything in my mind quiets down like an audience coming to a hush before the curtain opens, eagerly awaiting the start of something great. I hear his heart softly pounding. I forget the sound of my own name.

"What are you doing here?" I whisper.

"My week ended sooner than I thought. I worked extra hard to get things done so I could try and be with you for all this," he refers to the occasion surrounding us. "But you look like you've had it with being here, want to go somewhere else?"

Of course my knight knows how to rescue me.

We drive along the coast and it is still morning. This one pure moment of peace. I remember all the reasons happiness is important to me. I remember my need for vital life.

"I want to show you something special." *Boyfriend* says as we pull off to our favorite hiking trail through rock paths and wetlands and dwarf trees. He brings a helium balloon from the trunk of his car and a camera and we climb. At the top he says he saw this on TV and thought we should try it. He attaches the camera to the string of the balloon and sets a timer on it and lets it float up to the sky, disappearing in the sunlight.

"There's a GPS in it too, and the camera is set to take a picture every fifteen seconds. When the balloon bursts and it comes back to the ground we track it down, get the camera, and look at the photos. Neat, huh?"

I wish I had a camera and helium balloon I could send up into the timeline of my own life to get an aerial view on where I am and where I'm going.

We stand, looking up, excited to see the results, holding hands, and the sun shining on us from behind a cloud. Sometimes everything can be perfect even when nothing's figured out.

"Look, Allegra," he says suddenly, sounding serious. "I've been thinking for a while, maybe it's time to take our relationship to the next level. I know we've been apart for a while, but my heart can't stand being away from yours any longer. You've done an amazing job dealing with that stress. I know it's been hard for both of us but I'm so happy with the way it's made our love grow firmer and more certain, and all the challenges we've met together and became closer through."

The way he looks in my eyes I see the words in his heart before he even says them out loud. It's like they have a special mail man to my brain and he doesn't even need to speak. Sometimes we communicate the best in silence. I smile as we talk, overjoyed by how the tender love and care of our growing relationship is producing such rare and succulent fruit. It looks so

delicious and nourishing, in all the ways it should be.

“Allegra, what do you think about moving to North Carolina, to live there while I finish school? I know that you are in transition right now and figuring out what to do. And I know where we both see our relationship and courtship heading. I would be honored to have time in person with you each week, and to see who you are in your daily life, to let you see me on a regular basis and what that means for us. I really think the timing for this is right, and I really want you to pray about it.”

I let his words sink in the way melted butter permeates toast so you can no longer separate the two. I realize my eyebrows are raised and I let them soften.

I want so badly to be with him but I haven’t even figured out my own life yet. What looks like the perfect time actually feels like the most confusing. Adding another element into the mix might topple the whole arrangement on top of my tightrope.

But here we are standing at the top of this semi-mountain, climbing the heights together, and I’m about to hold us back from moving forward? I have to say something. He’s looking at me like I look scared.

“I will pray about it Sweetheart, but I really think I need to figure things out first before I do something huge like that. Living near you would be amazing. But I don’t want to just transfer my uncertainties to yet another place and make things more complicated all around.”

He moves to put his arm around me and it is strong. “I understand. I don’t want to make you do anything you’re not comfortable with or ready for. You think about it and I’ll still be here for you, wherever either of us are. You’re my One. We’ll get there when it’s right.” He leans the side of his head against mine for a moment as we look out over the terrain before us and see our balloon in the distance.

“So you probably haven’t had a chance to unpack your car from the move yet, huh?” I laugh at his knowing. “Want me to come help you?”

I say yes and we head back to the perfect house on the perfect beach. Strawberry Shortcake calls to us from the porch. My car poses a daunting task before me and I don’t want to confront all of what I left behind with nothing new to replace it. Like it’s all laughing at me for leaving. I’m glad *Boyfriend* is here to help.

We start pulling boxes out and bringing them to the attic, since all the rooms are occupied and I’ve just been sleeping on a trundle bed in the baby’s room. We pull out some handy kitchen gadgets shaped like the fruit or vegetable they are meant to assist with, reams of printer paper for all my future books, and trinkets he’s sent me while away.

Then we find the box of office supplies and decorations I kept at my desk. Part of me just wants to throw it in the ocean but there are some good quotes and photos in there that I’d love to put on another bulletin board.

I tell this to *Boyfriend* and he points out that being angry or resentful about that job might be keeping me from accepting where I am and the choices that I’ve made and have to deal with in order to move forward. He has a point. This whole time I’ve been thinking I’ve gotten free, only to be bound again by having to figure it all out. I know what is right for me, but because I chose it, but because I found it from within. It existed before I even did, and it knows how to hold everything together. Even seeming chaos. I suppose, maybe it’s not about your own ability to hold everything together when you’re rearranging your life. Maybe free means trusting in what’s true rather than in yourself.

I continue to move boxes and items more methodically, meticulously, and intentionally, like I am hyper aware and sensitive, like I have a sunburn on the bottom of my feet and have to

watch how I walk, like my mind is solving complex math equations in my head. In this subtle moment my life feels expansive, it feels calm, it feels like filling up with sun.

We finish unpacking and my family comes home and we all make dinner together. We have Grandma's special rhubarb pie and she finally shows *Boyfriend* and I how to make it in her secret way. She made it for her and Grandpa's first date ever. Her hands still knowing what to do and passing on what she would never teach me before. It almost feels like some secret initiation. I smell her perfume the entire time and it comforts me, knowing she is close.

Mom and Dad work on the baked zucchini lasagna and my sis and Doug pull basil and mint from the garden around the outside of the house and make their famous spritzers and tomato and mozzarella appetizers to welcome another summer. We even let Strawberry Shortcake try everything and she sings for us in the kitchen, which is growing dimmer in the setting sun, so we light candles and lanterns and bring them outside with us to eat. We play big band swing music from inside the house and Frank Sinatra. The breeze is both cool and warm at the same time and this is one of those magical moments where the family feels a stronghold of strength and support lifting each other up in such a time of change.

Chapter 10

I tell everyone that *Boyfriend* asked me if I'd consider moving to North Carolina and that after much introspection I've decided it would be an awesome opportunity to start doing what I love somewhere new. I will teach yoga and hold crafting classes, maybe work at a cafe or yarn store or organic market. It doesn't seem that important to know anymore. I'm no longer afraid that I'll be forced to sacrifice Life to make a living. I just need to follow what's right for me and trust it, even if it's different from what's right for everyone else. I was made for my own story, like the constellations on my neck were made for me, and not for the story the world is telling.

After dinner, and after everything is cleaned up and put away, *Boyfriend* goes to sleep on the couch and Grandma and I make apple and thyme infused tea before I go up to the baby's room for a night full of watercolor dreams. Grandma wraps the two of us in a soft chenille blanket and we sit outside on the porch swing. The candle wax is laying low in each jar and the summer bugs serenade us. We're quiet for a long time, we're wish gazing. We look at each star and listen to the cries made out to each one, to the dreams they hold for safekeeping. When I was little I used to imagine climbing up to my secret star constellation and putting my fears and ideas and desires in the cabinets of their brightness. They were safe there. She and Grandpa taught me how to do it.

Now I look at Grandma and she lets her grief roll down her cheeks. She doesn't make a sound, she doesn't sniffle her nose, she just releases her sadness so it doesn't eat away at her. I can feel her heart trembling deep inside, asking to be held. I see her wishes filling up the clouds and finding just the right star for safekeeping.

When she falls asleep next to me, I gently slip away and walk down to the beach. It's only me and the waves. I hear my breathing in sync with the in-and-out of their living. It feels like the sea is inside of me, lapping into my secret places, even the sore and tender ones, that I need to let someone see, like wounds that need air to breathe. I lay in the sand and hear it crunching against my body. Before I know it the ocean is lulling me to sleep and I don't wake up until the morning.

My eyes are still closed but I smell vanilla and honey mingled with spicy cardamon and dark black tea. I breathe it in deeply and open my eyes to the rising sun. It's not quite out from behind the horizon and *Boyfriend* woke me at the most perfect time with a steaming mug of chai. I've seen the sunrise many times, but it always takes my breath away. Creation's first act of the day is more beautiful than any artist's painting, is more original than a new idea even though it's the same thing day after day. It feels like it was made just for me.

"So that was a quick decision about moving to North Carolina," *Boyfriend* says quietly.

"It wasn't actually that fast. I've been thinking about it for a long time and asking God about it. It scared me to not have it all figured out and then to add something else for me to make happen. But I realized yesterday that was my problem, relying on myself to see it all through, rather than on the one who gave me those dreams in the first place. This really is the perfect time to get settled somewhere else, especially with all this going on." I point to the "For Sale" sign.

"Hey, look!" He says and points a little ways down the beach. "I guess we get to skip the GPS tracking altogether." I see the camera we sent off into the atmosphere yesterday nesting in the sand. We walk over to it and expectantly prepare ourselves to start viewing the pictures, not really sure of what we'll find. I am a little surprised that it actually turns one and seems to be working just fine.

"Allegra!" My mom calls from the house, what perfect timing. "Phone!"

I run up to the porch telling *Boyfriend* not to look at them without me. My mom tells me my phone wouldn't stop ringing so she had to come get me. It's Kaycee. She's having a horrible day at work and she's crying. Even though there have been some improvements at work she still feels the weight of being a rabbit asked to swim, rather than run. I talk to her about how important it is to listen to that and how she deserves the life she imagines. My heart is strong for her and I'm willing to be there to help her find the truth. We get off the phone and she is more encouraged, though I know what kind of journey lies before her if she chooses to take it.

I come back outside and we finally look at our treasure. First there are photos of the trees and then a little higher, photos of the surrounding streets, and tiny cars, it looks like a miniature world. The photos get higher and higher and the world and all our goings-on get smaller and smaller. Then we strike gold. There are photos right on the edge of our atmosphere. They give us a bird's eye view of the horizon. On one side is the dark and mysterious lushness of space, and on the other is swirling blue and white. We feel privileged to the secrets of the universe for a moment. We flip through the pictures, each one more stunning than the one before it. We stand speechless with the universe in the palm of our hands, with such careful and precious and tender holding. I wonder if this is what the stars feel like filled up with my dreams, if this is what the Maker feels like looking down at me.

I smile, knowing that life is mine for the choosing. I can wear sun dresses everyday. I can let my roots grow wild in fresh nutritious soil, and if the soil becomes toxic, I can always be replanted somewhere else.

We look up from being engrossed with our findings, startled by the quacking family of nearby ducks. They are all in a line paddling down the shoreline, the mama duck and all her babies. They are the poster children for *Make Way for Ducklings*, and I don't envy them at all. In fact, I have to laugh.

My ducks may never all be in a row, but sometimes, they line up to take a quick picture.

